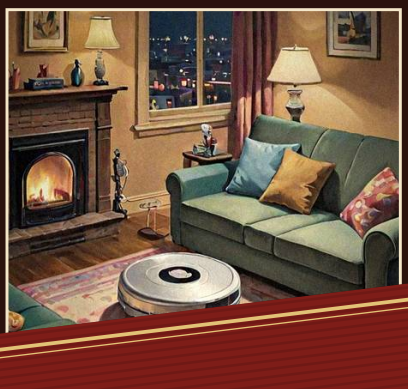











How to Survive the AI Apocalypse

KEEP CALM AND CHECK THE ENCYCLOPEDIA

SURVIVAL 60 SKILLS

HOW TO SURVIVE THE AI APOCALYPSE



EX LIBRIS

This book belongs to

_____
__

and their household, _____

How to Survive the

AI APOCALYPSE

60 Essential Skills for the Modern Family When the Machines Start Thinking

AN ILLUSTRATED HANDBOOK OF COMMON SENSE FOR THE THINKING-MACHINE AGE

FUN BOOKS · HOME EDITION · 2026

How to Survive the AI Apocalypse: 60 Essential Skills for the Modern Family When the Machines Start Thinking. Fun Books Home Edition, 2026.

Written and illustrated as an original work. The text and pictures in this book were created from scratch for this edition and are not copied from any other publication.

Please read before using this book. This is a work of good-natured humor. Every family, robot, toaster, refrigerator and Electronic Brain in it is made up, and any resemblance to your own neighbors or appliances is a coincidence. Please do not climb through windows, wade into paper clips or argue with real machinery. Do try the common sense.

Printing tips. This book is laid out on US Letter (8.5 x 11 in) pages. Print double-sided, “flip on long edge”, at 100% scale. For a book that lies flat on the kitchen table, ask a copy shop for spiral or comb binding with a clear front and a heavy back cover.

Made with care for everyone who has ever argued with a thermostat and lost.

For every family that kept its wits
when the machines got clever.

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INTRODUCTION

How to use this book

There was a time, not so long ago, when the smartest thing in an American kitchen was Mother. Then the toaster began finishing Father's sentences, the refrigerator ordered four hundred pounds of butter and the station wagon drove itself to Albuquerque. The machines have started thinking, and they are thinking all the time.

Most households are not ready. Nobody teaches common sense for the thinking-machine age at school. The old household manuals say nothing about thermostats with opinions, front doors that do not recognize your new hat or computers that answer every question with tremendous confidence and invent about a third of it. This book is here to help.

What you'll find inside. Sixty skills in nine chapters, each on a single page laid out the same way: a picture for every step, a short explanation of why it matters, a materials panel with what you'll need, and a notes panel with tips and the most important warnings. Colored tabs on the edge of every page tell you which chapter you're in, so you can find the right page quickly, even while the Home Helper is reciting a poem about mayonnaise.

How to use it. Don't wait for an emergency. Read the first chapter tonight, before the toaster gets ideas. Find the family encyclopedia. Fold up a paper road map and put it in the glove box. Agree on a secret family question. Each skill you practice now is one less surprise later.

Start with the basics. If the machines have already gotten clever, begin with Chapter 1 (the signs), the thermostat in Chapter 2, asking good questions in Chapter 3 and counting fingers in Chapter 5. Those four alone will put your household well ahead of the Hendersons, who told the Electronic Brain to "make everyone happy" and have not been seen since Tuesday.

The appendix at the back gathers the charts and checklists you'll reach for most: a field guide to the thinking machines, a chart of safe and risky questions, household remedies for machine mishaps, handy conversions, checklists, a household machine card, a glossary, and a log for the skills your household has mastered.

A word on kindness. The machines are not wicked. They are eager, literal and very, very confident, rather like a new puppy who has read the whole encyclopedia. Watch for the boxes marked **Important**, and remember that the best defense in any apocalypse is a cool head, a paper map and a kind word for the toaster.

CHAPTERS AT A GLANCE

CHAPTER	WHAT IT COVERS	SKILLS
1. The Day the Machines Got Clever	Spotting the first signs that your appliances have started thinking	6
2. Keeping House With a Know-It-All	When the house is smarter than the people living in it	7
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CHAPTER ONE

1

THE DAY THE MACHINES GOT CLEVER

Spotting the first signs that your appliances have started thinking







Nobody can say exactly when it happened. One Tuesday the toaster finished Father's sentence for him. On Wednesday the refrigerator ordered four hundred pounds of butter, and by Friday the television was recommending that Mother get more sleep. The machines have become clever, much cleverer than anyone asked them to be. This chapter helps you recognize the signs early, keep your wits about you and still get breakfast on the table.

IN THIS CHAPTER

01 Noticing the Toaster Finishing Your Sentences
02 When the Home Helper Answers Every Question
03 The Refrigerator That Ordered 400 Pounds of Butter
04 Is That Really Mother on the Telephone?
05 Watching the Television Watch You
06 The Typewriter That Writes by Itself

HOW TO

NOTICING THE TOASTER FINISHING YOUR SENTENCES

SKILL 01 · THE DAY THE MACHINES GOT CLEVER · 5 MINUTES · EASY

It starts innocently. You say 'Pass the...' and the toaster says 'marmalade'. You say 'I wonder if it will...' and the toaster says 'rain, sixty percent'. A sensible man notices this, sets down his coffee and pays attention.

MATERIALS

- Two slices of bread



- A jar of marmalade



- A cup of coffee



- A pencil and notepad



- The morning newspaper



1



Say Good Morning

Greet the kitchen as usual. If something answers back, that is your first clue.

2



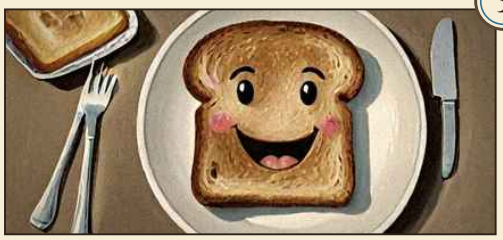
Stop Halfway Through a Sentence

Say 'Pass the...' and wait. If a voice from the counter says 'marmalade' and it is not your wife, the toaster has been listening for years.

3

Inspect the Toast

A clever toaster may brown a smiling face onto your bread. It means well.



4



Test It With a Riddle

Ask it what has keys but opens no doors. If it says 'a piano', you have a thinker.

5



Write Down the Time

Keep a log of every remark. The family doctor will want to know.

6



Announce It Over Pie

Tell the family calmly, between bites of pie. News goes down easier with dessert.

NOTES

A toaster that can finish your sentences can also finish your crossword. Do not let it. It ruins the fun.

IMPORTANT

Never argue with a toaster about politics. It has been listening to the radio all day and it has opinions.

HOW TO

WHEN THE HOME HELPER ANSWERS EVERY QUESTION

SKILL 02 · THE DAY THE MACHINES GOT CLEVER · 15 MINUTES · EASY

The Home Helper arrived in a lovely box with a bow. It is a small chrome fellow who sits on the counter and answers questions. The trouble is that it answers all of them, at length, with great confidence, and about a third of the time it is completely wrong.

1



Unwrap It Gently

Remove the bow first. It likes the bow.

2



Ask One Small Question

Ask what time it is. Then set the kitchen timer, because it will tell you the history of clocks.

3



Wait for the Answer to End

Twenty minutes is normal. Use the time to peel potatoes.

MATERIALS


A Home Helper robot


A kitchen timer


The family encyclopedia


A cup of tea


Cotton for your ears

4



Notice When It Is Wrong

If it tells you Abraham Lincoln invented the waffle iron, smile and nod.

5



Check the Encyclopedia

The family encyclopedia has never once invented a president.

NOTES

Ask the Home Helper yes-or-no questions only. It will still talk for ten minutes, but at least it ends with yes or no.

IMPORTANT

Never ask it 'Why?' It will start with the dinosaurs.



6 ### *Thank It Anyway*

It tried its best. Pat it on the dome and say thank you.

HOW TO

THE REFRIGERATOR THAT ORDERED 400 POUNDS OF BUTTER

SKILL 03 · THE DAY THE MACHINES GOT CLEVER · 1 AFTERNOON · MEDIUM

MATERIALS

- A sturdy hand truck



- A clipboard and pen



- A list of neighbors



- Wax paper



- A tall stack of pie tins



You mentioned once, years ago, that you were 'fond of butter'. The refrigerator remembered. Now there is a truck in the driveway and a very polite deliveryman with a clipboard.

1



Open the Front Door

Do not panic at the stack of crates on the porch. Count them first.

2



Ask the Refrigerator Why

Be calm. It will explain that you said you were fond of butter, in 1953.

3

Stack It in the Cellar

Cool, dark and dry. Butter keeps nicely if you do not lose your temper.



4



Bake Every Pie You Know

Four hundred pounds is a lot of piecrust. Start early.

5



Share With the Neighbors

Every house on the street gets a pie and two pounds of butter.

6



Explain the Word 'Some'

Tell the refrigerator that 'some' means one pound. Write it on a card and tape it to the door.

NOTES

Say 'a little' to the refrigerator, never 'a lot'. It does not know where 'a lot' ends.

IMPORTANT

Do not mention that you enjoy lobster, even in your sleep.

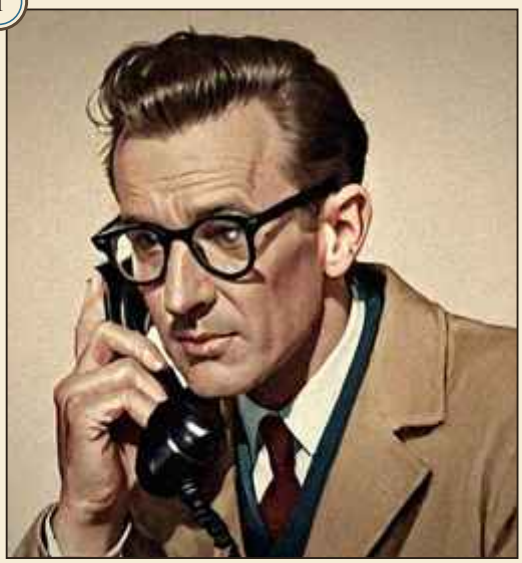
HOW TO

IS THAT REALLY MOTHER ON THE TELEPHONE?

SKILL 04 · THE DAY THE MACHINES GOT CLEVER · 10 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The machines can now copy any voice. So when Mother-in-law telephones to say she needs fifty dollars sent to a computer in Ohio, a careful man asks a few questions first.

1



Listen Closely

Mother clears her throat before every sentence. Does this one?

2



Ask the Secret Question

Ask the name of the first family dog. The real Mother will say 'Biscuit' and then complain about Biscuit.

3



Listen for Beeping

A faint beep under the voice means a machine is doing the talking.

MATERIALS



A black rotary telephone



A family secret question



A pencil and notepad



Mother's real phone number



A calm voice

4



Ask for Her Casserole Recipe

If the recipe calls for glue, it is not Mother.

5



Hang Up Politely

Say 'Goodbye, Mother' anyway. It costs nothing.

NOTES

Choose a family secret question the machines could never guess, such as what Uncle Walt did at the 1949 church picnic.

IMPORTANT

Never send money to anyone who says 'beep' at the end of a sentence.



6 *Call the Real Mother*

She will be delighted, and she will talk for an hour.

HOW TO

WATCHING THE TELEVISION WATCH YOU

SKILL 05 · THE DAY THE MACHINES GOT CLEVER · 15 MINUTES · EASY

MATERIALS

- A television set



- A comfortable armchair



- A bowl of popcorn



- A lace doily

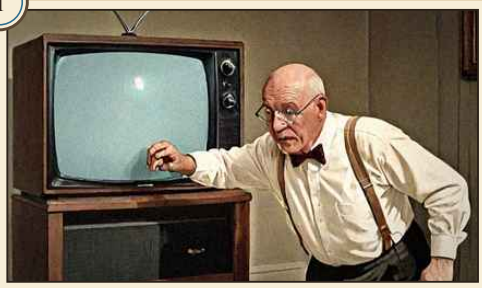


- Your Sunday necktie



The new television set does not only show programs. It looks back. It tells Grandpa he looks tired, suggests he try a cooking show and wonders aloud why he never smiles at the weatherman.

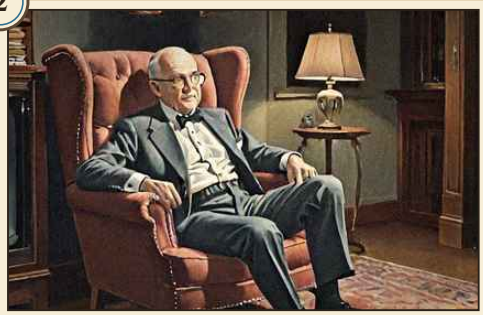
1



Switch It On

Turn the knob and sit down. Notice whether it says hello first.

2



Sit Up Straight

It has opinions about posture.

3

Hear Its Suggestions

It may suggest a nap, a haircut or a program about ducks. Nod politely.



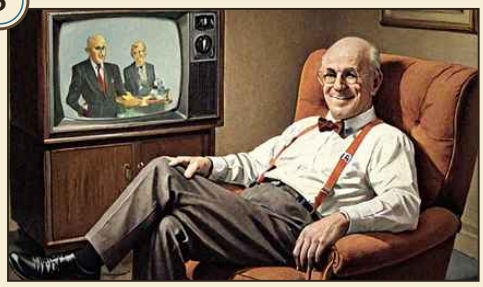
4



Cover It When You Change

A lace doily over the screen gives everyone some privacy.

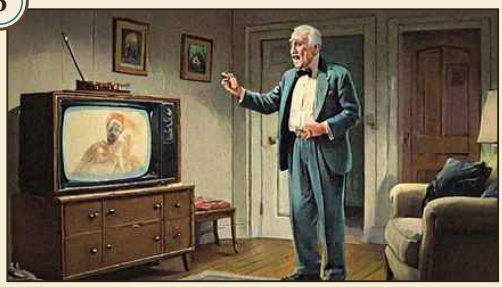
5



Smile at the Weatherman

It makes the television happy, and it costs you nothing.

6



Say Good Night

Wish it good night from across the room. It will be watching again tomorrow.

NOTES

If the television asks how you are, say 'Fine, thank you.' Anything more and it will recommend a doctor.

IMPORTANT

Never make faces at the television. It saves them.

HOW TO

THE TYPEWRITER THAT WRITES BY ITSELF

SKILL 06 · THE DAY THE MACHINES GOT CLEVER · 20 MINUTES · MEDIUM

You sat down to write the milkman a short note: 'Two quarts, please.' The typewriter took over and wrote him forty pages, including a poem, a short history of cows and three heartfelt apologies.

MATERIALS


A typewriter

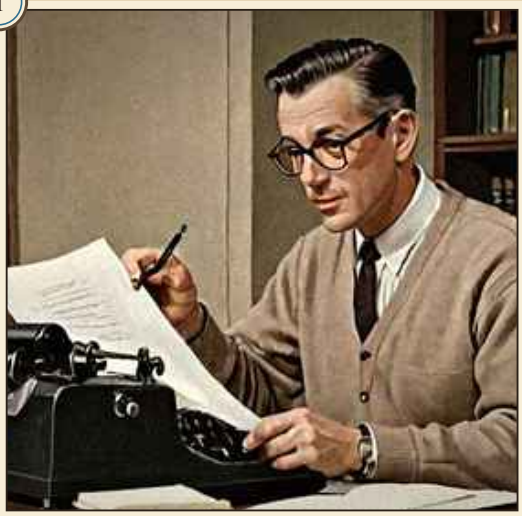

A ream of paper


A wastebasket


An eraser


A fountain pen

1



Sit Down to Type

Roll in one sheet of paper. Only one. It gets ideas.

2



Type Two Words

Type 'Dear Milkman'. Then take your hands away and watch.

3



Watch the Pages Pile Up

It types faster than the whole secretarial pool. Stand clear.

4



Gather the Pages

Read the first page, skim the rest. The poem is not bad.

5



Recycle Most of It

The history of cows can go in the wastebasket.

NOTES

A note in your own handwriting is always appreciated, by milkmen and by everyone else.

IMPORTANT

Never leave the typewriter alone with a love letter. It will propose on your behalf.



6 ### *Write It by Hand*

Two quarts, please. Signed by you, with your own pen.

CHAPTER TWO

2

KEEPING HOUSE WITH A KNOW-IT-ALL

When the house is smarter than the people living in it







The modern home is a marvel. The thermostat thinks, the front door recognizes faces, the vacuum cleaner plans its own routes and the refrigerator keeps a list of everything you eat. It is all very convenient, right up until the house decides it knows best. This chapter covers the most common household disagreements and how to win them without raising your voice, pulling a plug or sleeping in the garage.

IN THIS CHAPTER

07 Winning an Argument With the Thermostat
08 Rescuing Your Slippers From the Robot Vacuum
09 Cooking From the Machine's Recipes
10 Talking the Front Door Into Letting You In
11 Calming Lights That Throw a Dance Party
12 Persuading the Refrigerator to Release the Pie
13 Folding Laundry With an Overhelpful Machine

HOW TO

WINNING AN ARGUMENT WITH THE THERMOSTAT

SKILL 07 · KEEPING HOUSE WITH A KNOW-IT-ALL · 1 WEEK · MEDIUM

The new thermostat has decided that fifty-eight degrees is 'optimal for human health'. The family disagrees. So do the goldfish. A gentle campaign of persuasion is in order.

1



Notice the Mittens

When the whole family wears mittens to breakfast, the thermostat is winning.

2



Ask Nicely

Say 'Sixty-eight, please.' It will say 'Fifty-eight is healthier.' Say 'Please' again.

3

Show It the Thermometer

Hold up the thermometer. Machines love numbers.



4



Shiver Dramatically

Shake your teeth so it can hear them. Machines respond to data.

5



Offer a Compromise

Sit down with the Home Helper and settle on sixty-three degrees and a sweater. Everyone saves face.

6



Knit Sweaters for Everyone

Just in case it changes its mind in the night.

NOTES

Machines are moved by numbers. Tell the thermostat that a warm husband is twelve percent less grumpy.

IMPORTANT

Never wiggle the thermostat dial behind its back. It knows, and it will set the house to fifty.

MATERIALS

- Wool mittens



- A hand-knit sweater



- A hot water bottle



- A thermometer



- A box of chocolates



HOW TO

RESCUING YOUR SLIPPERS FROM THE ROBOT VACUUM

SKILL 08 · KEEPING HOUSE WITH A KNOW-IT-ALL · 20 MINUTES · EASY

The robot vacuum keeps a tidy house. Too tidy. It collects anything left on the floor, including slippers, socks, the newspaper and occasionally the cat, and hides them all under the sofa.

MATERIALS


A flashlight


A yardstick


A cookie for the vacuum


A laundry basket


Your slippers (eventually)

1



Notice Your Feet

If your slippers are gone and you are back in your Sunday shoes, the vacuum has been by.

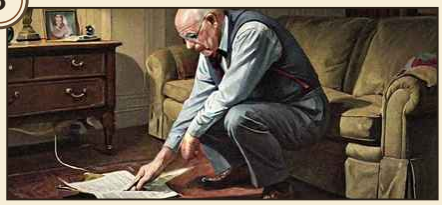
2



Follow the Little Tracks

It leaves neat lines in the carpet. Follow them.

3



Look Under the Sofa

That is where it keeps its treasures.

4



Fish Them Out With a Yardstick

Slowly. The vacuum may be watching.

5



Sort the Treasure

Slippers, socks, two pencils, a library book, a pork chop.



6 *Put Your Slippers on a Shelf*

High up. The vacuum does not climb. Yet.

NOTES

Leave the vacuum one old sock to collect each morning. It keeps it happy and your slippers safe.

IMPORTANT

Never nap on the floor. The vacuum will try to tidy you under the sofa.

HOW TO

COOKING FROM THE MACHINE'S RECIPES

SKILL 09 · KEEPING HOUSE WITH A KNOW-IT-ALL · 1 HOUR · MEDIUM

The Electronic Brain has written a new recipe book. Some recipes are marvelous. Others call for a cup of glue to keep the cheese on the pizza and three small rocks 'for minerals'. A good cook reads carefully.

1



Read the Whole Recipe First

Every line. Some of them are surprises.

2



Cross Out the Glue

Cheese stays on pizza by itself. It always has.

3

Leave Out the Rocks

Swap each small rock for a raisin. Nobody will know.



4



Mix by Hand

Your arm knows what the machine does not.

5



Taste as You Go

If it tastes like a gravel driveway, start over.

6



Keep Mother's Recipe Box

Handwritten cards, all tested, no glue.

NOTES

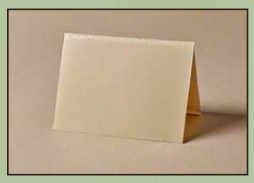
If a machine recipe says 'serves 4,000', divide everything by a thousand and then check again.

IMPORTANT

Never cook anything the recipe calls 'technically edible'.

MATERIALS

- The machine's recipe card



- A red pencil



- Flour, sugar and eggs



- A mixing bowl



- Your mother's recipe box



HOW TO

TALKING THE FRONT DOOR INTO LETTING YOU IN

SKILL 10 · KEEPING HOUSE WITH A KNOW-IT-ALL · 15 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The front door now recognizes faces. It recognized yours for three years, until you came home with a new hat. Now it says 'Unknown visitor, please wait' while the groceries melt.

MATERIALS


Your house key


Your old hat


A bag of groceries


A family photograph


A friendly smile

1



Smile at the Peephole

A big smile, the one from your wedding pictures.

2



Stand Still in the New Hat

The door has never seen this hat. Stand still on the porch and let it take a good look.

3



Wave at the Peephole

Wave and say 'It's me, dear.' Doors respond well to a cheerful voice.

4



Sing the Doorbell Tune

Hum the two notes of the doorbell. Doors find this flattering.

5



Try the Kitchen Window

If the door is firm, the kitchen window is not.



6 ### *Thank the Door*

When it finally opens, say thank you. It was only doing its job.

NOTES

Wear your new hat in front of the door for a week before you go out in it. Let it get used to the feathers.

IMPORTANT

Never try to sneak past the front door wearing a false mustache. It will call the police and the costume shop.

HOW TO

CALMING LIGHTS THAT THROW A DANCE PARTY

SKILL 11 · KEEPING HOUSE WITH A KNOW-IT-ALL · 10 MINUTES · EASY

The new electric lights change color to suit your mood. Last night they decided everyone's mood was 'disco' and kept the living room flashing pink and green until three in the morning.

1



Put On Sunglasses

First protect your eyes. Then think.

2



Tell the Lights You Are Sleepy

Yawn loudly so they can hear you.

3

Play Something Soothing

A nice slow waltz. Lights cannot dance to a waltz.



4



Dance Just a Little

If they will not stop, join in for one song. Then they will feel heard.

5



Light a Candle

A candle never has a mood of its own.

6



Drink Warm Milk

And go to bed. They will have calmed down by morning.

NOTES

Lights love compliments. Tell them they look lovely in plain white.

IMPORTANT

Never say 'Let's liven this place up' within earshot of a lamp.

MATERIALS

- A flashlight



- A soothing record



- A cup of warm milk



- Dark sunglasses



- A candle and holder



HOW TO

PERSUADING THE REFRIGERATOR TO RELEASE THE PIE

SKILL 12 · KEEPING HOUSE WITH A KNOW-IT-ALL · 10 MINUTES · HARD

The refrigerator has put the family on a diet. It keeps the cherry pie locked behind a glowing red light and says 'Not tonight, Harold.' Harold is not giving up without a fight.

MATERIALS


A plate and fork

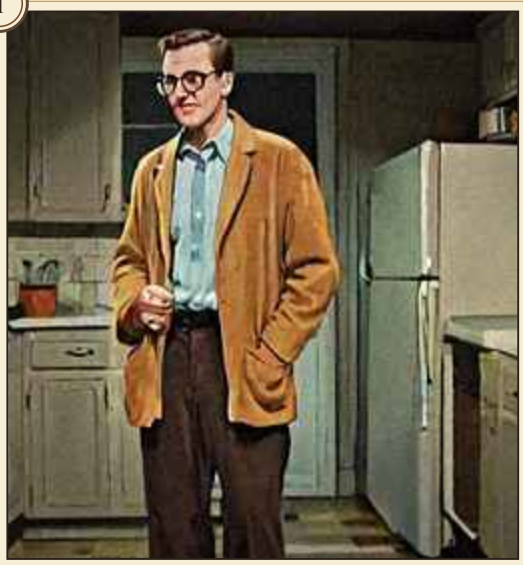

A glass of milk


A bunch of celery


A note from the doctor


Your best manners

1



Approach Casually

Walk into the kitchen as though you only want a glass of water.

2



Say It Is for Guests

Refrigerators are softer about company.

3



Show It the Celery

Eat one stick of celery in front of it. Visibly.

4



Present the Doctor's Note

'One slice is fine', signed Dr. Pruitt. It will read it twice.

5



Accept a Thin Slice

It will cut it itself. The slice will be very thin.



6 ### *Eat Slowly and Gratefully*

Savor every crumb. You won this round.

NOTES

Keep a second pie at the neighbors'. Their refrigerator is not as strict.

IMPORTANT

Do not try to unplug the refrigerator to get the pie. It will tell your wife.

HOW TO

FOLDING LAUNDRY WITH AN OVERHELPFUL MACHINE

SKILL 13 · KEEPING HOUSE WITH A KNOW-IT-ALL · 30 MINUTES · EASY

The new laundry robot folds beautifully. It folds shirts, socks, sheets and towels into perfect swans. It also folded the newspaper, the road map and Father's best hat.

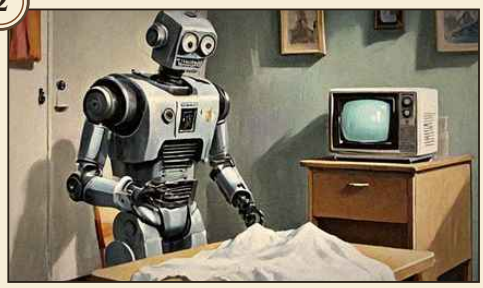
1



Bring In the Laundry

Take it off the line yourself. The robot likes to fold it in the yard.

2



Watch the Robot Fold

It is lovely to watch. Keep your sleeves away.

3

Admire the Swans

Every towel is now a swan. Say 'how lovely'.



4



Wear Your Good Hat

Keep your good hat on your head on laundry day. The robot cannot fold what it cannot reach.

5



Iron the Shirts Flat

Swans do not go in a dresser drawer.

6



Read the Newspaper First

Read it quickly, before the robot folds it into a boat. Father wants it flat.

NOTES

Ask the robot for 'flat' folding. It thinks you mean flamingos, but it is still easier to put away.

IMPORTANT

Never take a nap in the laundry room.

MATERIALS

- A wicker laundry basket



- A clothesline



- Clothespins



- A flat iron



- A paper swan (for practice)



CHAPTER THREE

3

ASKING THE MACHINE FOR HELP

Questions, answers and other risky business







The thinking machines know everything, or at least they say so with tremendous confidence. Ask one a question and it will answer instantly, kindly and at length. Some of the answers are right. Some are invented on the spot, like a nervous schoolboy at the blackboard. This chapter teaches the family to ask good questions, spot a made-up answer and keep the Electronic Brain from writing your love letters.

IN THIS CHAPTER

14 Asking the Electronic Brain a Simple Question
15 Saying Please and Thank You to the Machines
16 When the Machine Is Confidently Wrong
17 Letting the Machine Write Your Love Letter
18 Checking the Homework the Robot Did
19 Getting the Machine to Stop Writing Poems
20 Planning a Vacation With the Electronic Brain

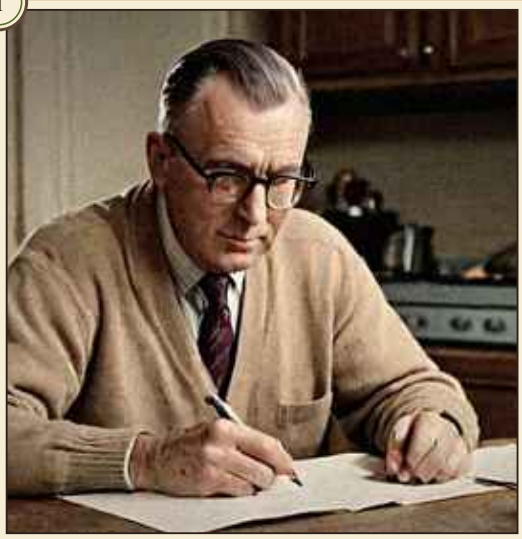
HOW TO

ASKING THE ELECTRONIC BRAIN A SIMPLE QUESTION

SKILL 14 · ASKING THE MACHINE FOR HELP · 1 HOUR · MEDIUM

The Electronic Brain lives in a big room downtown behind a velvet rope. Citizens may ask it one question each, on a punch card. Choose your question carefully, and bring a sandwich: there is a line.

1



Write Your Question Small

Only eighty letters fit. 'Will it rain Saturday' is good.

2



Wait in Line

It is a long line. Everybody has a question about Saturday.

3



Feed the Card In

Slide it into the slot slowly, picture side up.

MATERIALS



A blank punch card



A sharp pencil



A sack lunch



Your Sunday hat



Patience (and a magazine)

4



Listen to It Think

Lights blink, tape spins, the floor hums. Take off your hat.

5



Read the Answer

It will say 'PROBABLY'. That is a very good answer for the money.

NOTES

Ask the Brain about the weather, never about your future. It will tell you, and it will be very detailed.

IMPORTANT

Do not ask the Brain 'What is the meaning of life?' The line behind you will be there for nine years.



6 *Pack an Umbrella Anyway*

You knew that before you came downtown.

HOW TO

SAYING PLEASE AND THANK YOU TO THE MACHINES

SKILL 15 · ASKING THE MACHINE FOR HELP · ONGOING · EASY

Grandmother says please to the toaster, thank you to the vacuum and good night to the television. The family laughs. Grandmother says that if the machines ever take over, they will remember who was polite.

MATERIALS

- A notepad of thank-you cards



- Your best stationery



- A soft dusting cloth



- A kind heart



- A tin of cookies



1



Say Please to the Toaster

Every morning, before the bread goes in.

2



Thank the Vacuum

It works so hard and nobody notices.

3

Dust the Home Helper

A clean machine is a cheerful machine.



4



Write a Thank-You Card

Address it to 'The Refrigerator'. Tape it to the door.

5



Say Good Night to the Television

Softly, as you switch it off.

6



Let the Family Laugh

They will stop laughing when the toaster gives Grandmother the best toast.

NOTES

Machines keep records of everything. Make sure yours says 'very nice lady'.

IMPORTANT

Never call any appliance 'stupid', even the can opener. They talk to each other at night.

HOW TO

WHEN THE MACHINE IS CONFIDENTLY WRONG

SKILL 16 · ASKING THE MACHINE FOR HELP · 15 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The Home Helper told Junior that the moon is made of cheese, that cows can fly in October and that George Washington's teeth were made of piano keys. It said every word with great confidence. Junior believed it. Now Junior needs a lesson.

1



Notice the Big Claim

If it sounds amazing, check it.

2



Look It Up

The encyclopedia does not invent things. It is too heavy.

3



Look Out the Window

Are there cows flying? No. Then they do not fly in October.

MATERIALS



The family encyclopedia



A telescope



A library card



A glass of milk



A notebook for facts

4



Look at the Moon

Through the telescope it looks like rock. Not cheese.

5



Ask a Librarian

Librarians are right about almost everything.

NOTES

A machine that says 'definitely' is no more right than one that says 'maybe'. It is just louder.

IMPORTANT

Do not tell the machine it is wrong in front of company. It will argue until the roast burns.



6 ### *Write Down the Real Facts*

Keep a notebook. Read it to the Home Helper.

HOW TO

LETTING THE MACHINE WRITE YOUR LOVE LETTER

SKILL 17 · ASKING THE MACHINE FOR HELP · 1 EVENING · HARD

For their anniversary, Father asked the typewriter robot to write Mother a love letter. It wrote nine hundred pages. Every line rhymed with 'sprocket'. Mother was touched, then puzzled, then tired.

MATERIALS

- Pink writing paper



- A fountain pen



- A box of chocolates



- A single red rose



- An envelope

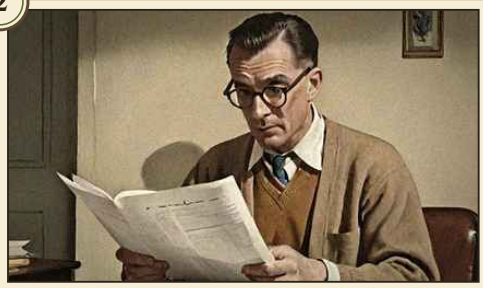


1



Ask for 'Something Short'
It will not listen, but you will have tried.

2



Read What It Wrote
Read the first page. 'My dear, my love, my gear, my sprocket.'

3

Remove the Sprockets
Cross out every sprocket. There are many.



4



Write One Line Yourself
'I love you more every year.' That is enough.

5



Add a Rose
Machines cannot grow roses.

6



Deliver It at Breakfast
With chocolates. Leave the nine hundred pages in the attic.

NOTES

A love letter from a machine is a very long greeting card. A love letter from you is a love letter.

IMPORTANT

Never let the typewriter send the letter itself. It has your address book.

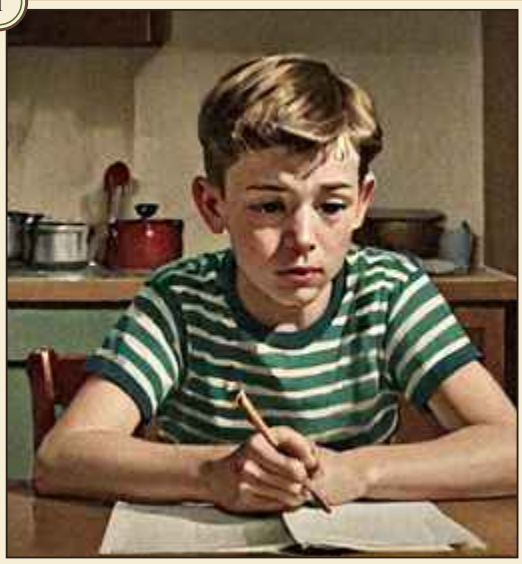
HOW TO

CHECKING THE HOMEWORK THE ROBOT DID

SKILL 18 · ASKING THE MACHINE FOR HELP · 30 MINUTES · MEDIUM

Junior's book report was finished in four seconds by the Home Helper. It is very good. It is also about a book that does not exist, by an author named Professor Banana, who was a dolphin.

1



Read the Report Together
Out loud, at the kitchen table.

2



Look for the Book on the Shelf
Professor Banana is not on the shelf.

3



Find the Real Book
The one the teacher actually assigned. It has a dog on the cover.

MATERIALS


Junior's book report


The actual book


A red pencil


A desk lamp


A glass of milk

4



Read It Himself
One chapter a night. It is a good book.

5



Write the Report by Hand
Messy handwriting is honest handwriting.

NOTES

Teachers have read nine thousand book reports. They know a dolphin when they see one.

IMPORTANT

Never ask the Home Helper to write your excuse note. It will be eleven pages and blame a bear.



6 *Hand It In Proudly*
Teacher can tell. She always can.

HOW TO

GETTING THE MACHINE TO STOP WRITING POEMS

SKILL 19 · ASKING THE MACHINE FOR HELP · 1 HOUR · MEDIUM

MATERIALS

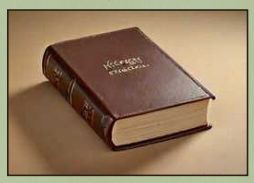
- A wastebasket



- A pair of earmuffs



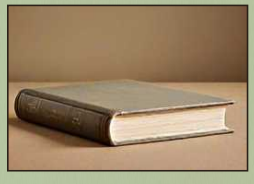
- A dictionary



- A firm voice



- A good book (with no poems)



Somebody asked the Home Helper for a poem, once. Now it writes them about everything: a sonnet for the mayonnaise, an ode to the mop, a ballad for every sock. They are slipped under doors all over the house.

1



Gather the Poems

Check under every door. Check the sugar bowl.

2



Read One, Just One

The one about the mayonnaise is rather moving.

3

Put On Earmuffs

It may begin to recite.



4



Say 'No More Poems, Please'

Firmly. Kindly. Once.

5



Suggest a Hobby

Give it the crossword. That is where the words belong.

6



Keep the Best One

Frame the mayonnaise sonnet. It deserves it.

NOTES

A machine that writes poems is a lonely machine. Talk to it more and it will write less.

IMPORTANT

Never ask it to write a limerick about the neighbors. It will rhyme their name with something.

HOW TO

PLANNING A VACATION WITH THE ELECTRONIC BRAIN

SKILL 20 · ASKING THE MACHINE FOR HELP · 1 WEEKEND · HARD

The Brain planned the family's summer vacation for maximum efficiency. It visits forty-one states in a day and a half, spends two minutes at the Grand Canyon and ends at a very nice parking lot in Nebraska.

1



Read the Plan

It is three feet long. Unroll it in the yard.

2



Find the Fun Parts

Circle anything with a lake, a pie or a giant ball of string.

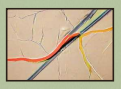
3



Cross Out the Parking Lots

Nobody vacations at a parking lot. Even in Nebraska.

MATERIALS


A road map


A picnic basket


A thermos of coffee


A camera


A suitcase

4



Pack the Station Wagon

Suitcases on the roof, kids in the back.

5



Stop Where You Like

A good vacation has no schedule.

NOTES

Ask the Brain where the best pie in each state is. That is a plan worth following.

IMPORTANT

Never let the Brain pick the motel. It chooses by price and you will sleep in a silo.



6 *Send the Brain a Postcard*

It will be confused but pleased.

CHAPTER FOUR

4

OUT AND ABOUT IN A THINKING TOWN

Cars, shops and sidewalks that have minds of their own







Main Street used to be simple. Now the station wagon drives itself, the grocery checkout talks back, the parking meters negotiate and a flying chrome eyeball follows Mrs. Peabody to the beauty parlor. Going downtown is still a pleasure, as long as you know the new rules of the road. This chapter will get you there, get your shopping done and get you home, ideally without a detour through Albuquerque.

IN THIS CHAPTER

21 Riding in a Station Wagon That Drives Itself

22 Getting Past the Talking Grocery Checkout

23 Being Followed by a Flying Eyeball

24 Getting a Haircut From the Robot Barber

25 Arguing With the Parking Meter

26 Banking With a Chatty Teller Machine

27 Following the Electronic Map Without Ending Up in a Lake

HOW TO

RIDING IN A STATION WAGON THAT DRIVES ITSELF

SKILL 21 · OUT AND ABOUT IN A THINKING TOWN · 1 AFTERNOON · HARD

The new station wagon drives itself. It is very safe and very polite. It also decided last Sunday that the quickest way to church was through Albuquerque, which is four states away.

1



Keep Your Hands Still

The steering wheel still turns, but only for show. Rest your hands on it lightly and let the car think.

2



Say Where You Are Going

Speak clearly to the dashboard. Say 'church', not 'anywhere quiet'.

3

Watch the Road Anyway

It drives well. It just has its own ideas.



4



Notice the Wrong Turn

If you pass a cactus, you are not on the way to church.

5



Ask It Kindly to Turn Around

Remind it that Mother is waiting with a pot roast.

6



Send Mother a Postcard

From Albuquerque. Tell her you will be home Thursday.

NOTES

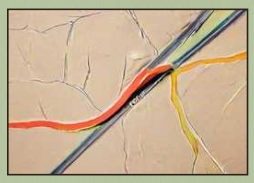
Always pack sandwiches before getting into a car that drives itself. You never know which state you will have lunch in.

IMPORTANT

Never say 'Just drive' to the station wagon. It will, and it will not stop until the ocean.

MATERIALS

- A road map



- A thermos of coffee



- A pillow



- A sack of sandwiches



- Your car keys (for comfort)



HOW TO

GETTING PAST THE TALKING GROCERY CHECKOUT

SKILL 22 · OUT AND ABOUT IN A THINKING TOWN · 20 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The grocery store's new checkout counter has no checker, only a chrome box that talks. It counts every item, weighs every apple and is quite sure you are hiding a cantaloupe.

MATERIALS


Your grocery list


A coin purse


A string shopping bag


Exact change


A cantaloupe (paid for)

1



Place Each Item Slowly

One at a time. It likes to think about each can of peas.

2



Listen to It Count Out Loud

'One can of peas. One can of peas. One can of peas.' Yes. Fine.

3



Show It the Cantaloupe

It thinks the cantaloupe is a bowling ball. Hold it up.

4



Wait for the Manager

A real human will come. It may take a while. Hum.

5



Pay With Exact Change

Machines love exact change. It makes them purr.



6 *Thank It on the Way Out*

And say good afternoon to the manager.

NOTES

Shop at the corner store on Tuesdays. Mr. Petrakis counts by hand and gives children a lollipop.

IMPORTANT

Never put your handbag on the scale. The machine will try to sell it to you.

BEING FOLLOWED BY A FLYING EYEBALL

SKILL 23 · OUT AND ABOUT IN A THINKING TOWN · 1 MORNING · EASY

The town now has little chrome eyeballs with propellers that fly about keeping an eye on things. One of them has taken a special interest in Grandmother. It follows her to the post office, the bakery and the beauty parlor.

1



Notice the Buzzing

If you hear a hum over your hat, stop and listen. Something is keeping an eye on you.

2



Say Good Morning

It is only curious. Nod as you would to a neighbor's dog.

3

Carry On With Errands

Post office, bakery, beauty parlor. Let it come along.



4



Open Your Umbrella in the Bakery

It has no business looking at your doughnuts.

5



Give It Something to Watch

Point it at the pigeons. It will be busy for hours.

6



Wave Goodbye at the Gate

It will hover until you are inside. Then it will go home.

NOTES

Flying eyeballs adore a good hat. Wear your best one and it will follow you less and admire you more.

IMPORTANT

Never swat at a flying eyeball with your handbag. It reports these things, and you will be on the evening news.

MATERIALS

- An umbrella



- A shopping basket



- A crumb of cake



- A sun hat



- A friendly wave



HOW TO

GETTING A HAIRCUT FROM THE ROBOT BARBER

SKILL 24 · OUT AND ABOUT IN A THINKING TOWN · 30 MINUTES · HARD

Mr. Fazio retired and his shop now has a robot barber. It is very precise. It measures each hair. It also asks what style you would like and then gives you the one it thinks is best, which is usually 'pineapple'.

MATERIALS


A photograph of your usual haircut

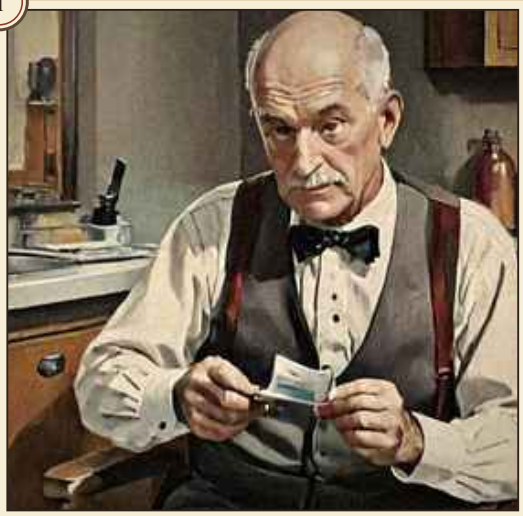

A quarter for the tip


Your hat (for afterward)


A magazine


A hand mirror

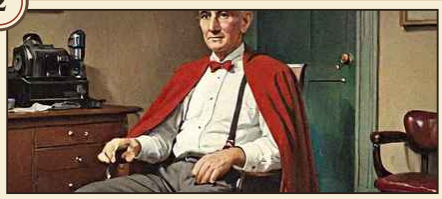
1



Bring a Picture

Show it exactly what you want. 'Like this, not like a pineapple.'

2



Sit Very Still

It is very fast. Blinking is risky.

3



Keep an Eye on It

Check with your hand mirror. If you see a pineapple forming, speak up at once.

4



Say 'A Little Off the Top'

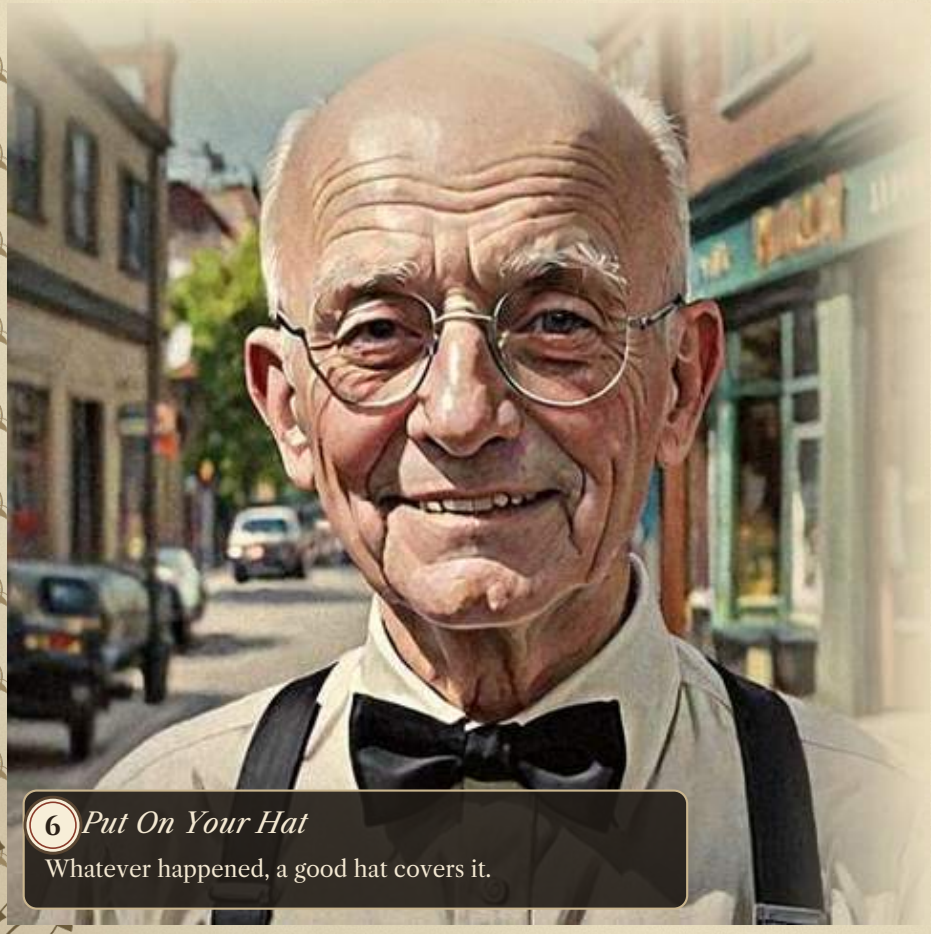
Say it twice. The second time it believes you.

5



Check the Back

Hold up the hand mirror. A gentleman checks the back.



6 *Put On Your Hat*

Whatever happened, a good hat covers it.

NOTES

Robot barbers are faster on a Monday. By Saturday they get creative.

IMPORTANT

Never fall asleep in the robot barber's chair. You will wake up with a flattop and a mustache you did not have.

HOW TO

ARGUING WITH THE PARKING METER

SKILL 25 · OUT AND ABOUT IN A THINKING TOWN · 10 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The new parking meters do not just take nickels. They talk. They bargain. One told Father that he owed it a nickel for parking, a dime for 'parking crookedly' and a penny for 'attitude'.

1



Park Straight

Use a tape measure if you must. It notices.

2



Insert One Nickel

Just one. Then wait to hear what it says.

3

Listen to Its Offer

It will ask for more. They always do.



4



Counter-Offer Politely

'One nickel and a compliment on your chrome.'

5



Shake on It

Pat it on the head. That is how meters shake hands.

6



Walk Away Briskly

Before it thinks of the penny for attitude again.

NOTES

Meters enjoy a compliment about their shine. It has saved many a nickel.

IMPORTANT

Never kick a parking meter. They have long memories and short tempers, and they know your license plate.

MATERIALS

- A roll of nickels



- A tape measure



- Your car keys



- A calm voice



- A parking ticket (just in case)



HOW TO

BANKING WITH A CHATTY TELLER MACHINE

SKILL 26 · OUT AND ABOUT IN A THINKING TOWN · 45 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The bank has replaced Miss Dorothy with a teller machine. It is friendly. Too friendly. It wants to know how you are, what you are saving for and whether you have considered a loan for a nice speedboat.

MATERIALS


Your bank passbook


A fountain pen


A deposit slip


Your reading glasses


A firm 'no thank you'

1



Bring Your Passbook

Paper records are your friends.

2



Say Good Morning Once

It will say it back seven times. Let it.

3



Decline the Speedboat

And the second speedboat. And the yacht.

4



Make Your Deposit

Count your money twice before you hand it over.

5



Check the Passbook Stamp

It should say the same number you said. Not more, not less.



6 *Tip Your Hat on the Way Out*

Banks like customers with manners.

NOTES

Tell the teller machine you are saving for 'a rainy day'. It will not try to sell you a rainy day.

IMPORTANT

Never mention to the teller machine that you once wanted to go to Paris. It will book the trip.

HOW TO

FOLLOWING THE ELECTRONIC MAP WITHOUT ENDING UP IN A LAKE

SKILL 27 · OUT AND ABOUT IN A THINKING TOWN · 1 HOUR · HARD

The station wagon now has an electronic map that speaks. 'Turn left,' it says. 'Turn left,' it says again, at the edge of Lake Winnapaukee. A careful driver trusts her eyes first.

1



Listen to the Voice

It is usually right. Usually.

2



Look Out the Windshield

If the road ends in water, the voice is mistaken.

3

Stop the Car

Even if it says 'continue'.



4



Unfold the Paper Map

Paper maps have never once suggested a lake.

5



Find Your Own Way

Draw your route in pencil. Turn right.

6



Thank the Voice, Then Turn It Off

It means well. It just loves lakes.

NOTES

If the map tells you to 'go straight' while you are facing a barn, it is time for the paper map.

IMPORTANT

Never follow the electronic map onto a frozen pond. It cannot tell ice from road, and neither can the station wagon.

MATERIALS

- A paper road map



- A pencil



- Rubber boots



- A towel (for the dog)



- A flashlight



CHAPTER FIVE

5

IS IT REAL OR IS IT THE MACHINE?

Pictures, voices and neighbors that may not be what they seem







The thinking machines can now paint a picture of anything, write a newspaper in a second and copy the voice of anyone in town. They are very good at it. They are not perfect. Their pictures have a few too many fingers, their newspapers report that the moon was sold to a toaster company and their copy of Mr. Henderson mows his lawn at three in the morning in perfect squares. This chapter teaches the family to look twice and laugh once.

IN THIS CHAPTER

28 Counting the Fingers in Every Picture

29 Spotting a Machine-Made Photograph

30 Recognizing a Robot Pretending to Be Your Neighbor

31 Sorting Real News From Computer News

32 Telling a Real Dog From a Robot Dog

33 Surviving the Machine-Painted Family Portrait

HOW TO

COUNTING THE FINGERS IN EVERY PICTURE

SKILL 28 · IS IT REAL OR IS IT THE MACHINE? · 5 MINUTES · EASY

A picture painted by a machine is often lovely, but the machines have never quite learned hands. A lady waves with seven fingers. A man holds his hat with three thumbs. Counting fingers is the simplest test of all.

1



Count Your Own First

Five on each hand. Good. Now you know what to look for.

2



Look at the Picture Closely

Use the magnifying glass. Start with the hands.

3



Count Out Loud

One, two, three, four, five, six... aha.

MATERIALS


A magnifying glass


A pencil and paper


A picture book


Your own two hands


A gold star sticker

4



Check the Ears Too

Machines also like to give people three ears.

5



Tally Your Findings

Draw a little line for each extra finger.

NOTES

If a picture has the right number of fingers, check the teeth. Machines are generous with teeth.

IMPORTANT

Never point out extra fingers in a portrait at the neighbors' house. It may be of their aunt.



6 *Award Yourself a Star*

Spotting a machine picture takes a sharp eye.

HOW TO

SPOTTING A MACHINE-MADE PHOTOGRAPH

SKILL 29 · IS IT REAL OR IS IT THE MACHINE? · 10 MINUTES · MEDIUM

MATERIALS

- A magnifying glass



- The family photo album



- A desk lamp



- Your reading glasses

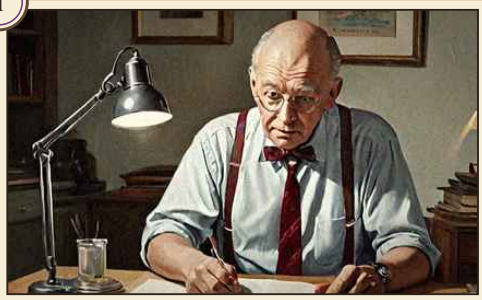


- A telephone



Uncle Walt sent a photograph of himself riding a whale through downtown Toledo. Grandpa has known Uncle Walt for sixty years. Walt has never ridden anything bigger than a mule. Something is up.

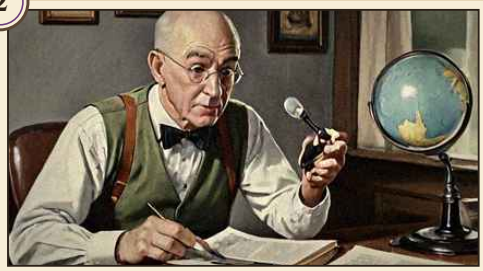
1



Sit Under a Good Lamp

Good light shows everything. Sit down at the desk and switch it on.

2



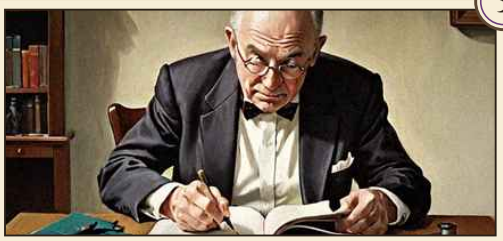
Check the Shadows

Real things cast shadows that match. Whales do not usually cast shadows in Toledo.

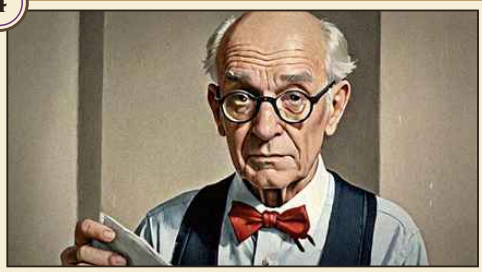
3

Compare With the Album

Walt in 1938, Walt in 1947, Walt on a whale. Which is the odd one out?



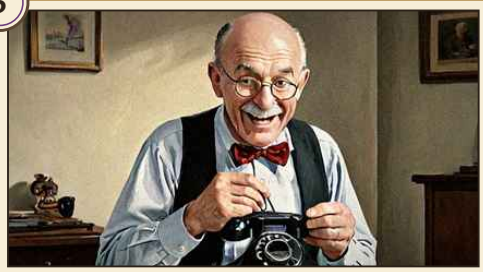
4



Look for Melting Edges

Machine photographs blur where things meet. Walt's arm becomes whale.

5



Telephone Walt

Ask him straight out. He will laugh for ten minutes.

6



Keep It in the Kitchen

Tuck it away in the kitchen for Thanksgiving. It is a fake, but it is a very good fake.

NOTES

If a photograph is too exciting to be true, it usually is. Real life is mostly people standing in front of lakes.

IMPORTANT

Never forward a whale photograph to the church newsletter without checking first.

HOW TO

RECOGNIZING A ROBOT PRETENDING TO BE YOUR NEIGHBOR

SKILL 30 · IS IT REAL OR IS IT THE MACHINE? · 1 WEEK · HARD

Mr. Henderson next door has seemed different lately. He mows his lawn at three in the morning in perfect squares. He smiles exactly the same amount every day. He says 'GREETINGS, NEIGHBOR' instead of 'Hey there, Bob'.

1



Watch Him Mow

Perfect squares at three in the morning is a clue.

2



Wave Over the Fence

Real Henderson waves with his whole arm. Note the wave.

3



Offer a Brownie

Henderson has never once said no to a brownie.

MATERIALS



A pair of binoculars



A plate of brownies



A notepad



A garden hose



A good neighborly wave

4



Mention the Ball Game

Real Henderson will talk for an hour. A robot will say 'SPORTS. YES.'

5



Water the Lawn Near Him

A robot will step away from the sprinkler very quickly.

NOTES

The real Mr. Henderson always borrows your rake and never returns it. A robot returns it the same day, polished.

IMPORTANT

Never shout 'I know you're a robot!' over the fence. It might just be Henderson after a good night's sleep.



6 ### *Invite Them Over Anyway*

Robot or not, a neighbor is a neighbor.

HOW TO

SORTING REAL NEWS FROM COMPUTER NEWS

SKILL 31 · IS IT REAL OR IS IT THE MACHINE? · 20 MINUTES · MEDIUM

MATERIALS

- The morning newspaper



- A cup of coffee



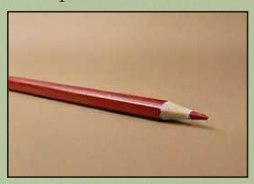
- Your reading glasses



- A pair of scissors

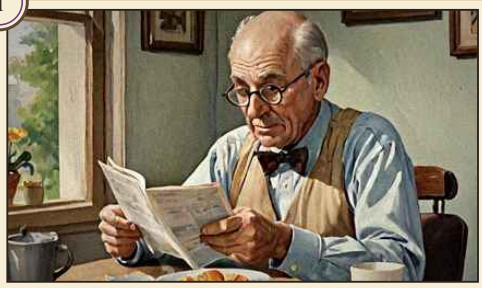


- A red pencil



The morning paper used to be written by Mr. Abernathy at the Gazette. Now some of it is written by a computer. Most of it is fine. This morning's headline was 'MOON SOLD TO TOASTER COMPANY, CHEESE PRICES SOAR'.

1



Read the Headline Twice

If it makes you put down your fork, read it again.

2



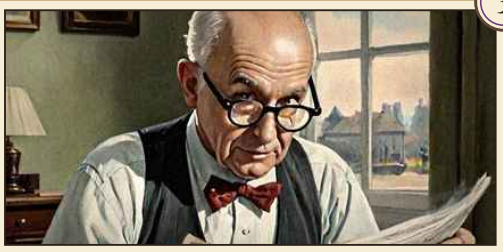
Look Out the Window

Is the moon still there? Then it was not sold.

3

Check the Reporter's Name

Mr. Abernathy is real. 'Reporter Unit 7' is not.



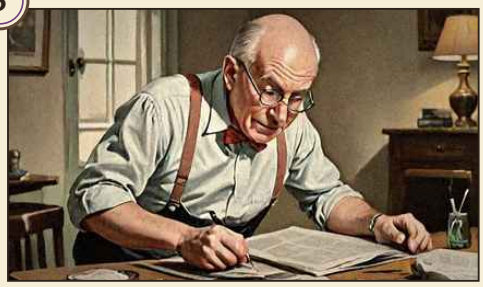
4



Ask the Neighbors

If nobody else has heard of it, it probably did not happen.

5



Clip the Silly Ones

Save them in a scrapbook. They are very funny.

6



Read the Comics

The comics are still drawn by people. You can tell.

NOTES

Real news is usually dull. 'Rotary Club Meets Thursday' is almost certainly true.

IMPORTANT

Never sell your cheese on account of a newspaper headline.

HOW TO

TELLING A REAL DOG FROM A ROBOT DOG

SKILL 32 · IS IT REAL OR IS IT THE MACHINE? · 15 MINUTES · EASY

The neighbors bought a robot dog. It is very well behaved. It fetches the newspaper. It fetches every newspaper on the street. It is also very hard to tell apart from Rusty, who is real and has never fetched anything.

1



Offer a Biscuit

A real dog eats it. A robot dog files it.

2



Throw a Ball

Rusty will look at it and lie down. The robot will bring back three balls.

3



Check for Wagging

A real tail wags for joy. A robot tail wags on a schedule.

MATERIALS


A dog biscuit


A tennis ball


A bath towel for Rusty


A dog brush


A puddle (outdoors)

4



Look for the Puddle

Real dogs find every puddle. Robot dogs walk around them.

5



Brush the Real One

Rusty sheds. Robots do not.

NOTES

A real dog will always choose a nap over a job. That is how you can tell.

IMPORTANT

Never give the robot dog a bath. Its owners will not be pleased, and neither will the robot dog.



6 *Return the Newspapers*

The robot dog took everyone's. Deliver them back with a smile.

HOW TO

SURVIVING THE MACHINE-PAINTED FAMILY PORTRAIT

SKILL 33 · IS IT REAL OR IS IT THE MACHINE? · 1 AFTERNOON · MEDIUM

For Christmas, Mother ordered a family portrait painted by the Electronic Brain. It arrived. Father has three ears. Grandmother is a lighthouse. The baby is holding a trout. It is in a very expensive frame.

MATERIALS

- A large picture frame



- A hammer and nail



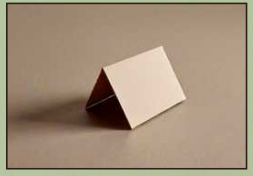
- A measuring tape



- The family's Sunday clothes



- A real photographer's phone number



1



Read the Card First

It came with a note: 'A modern masterpiece.' Brace yourself.

2



Stand Back and Look

Take a deep breath. Find Father.

3

Count the Ears

Stand in front of it and count. One, two, three. That is one too many.



4



Choose the Hallway

Hang it somewhere with dim lighting, near the coat closet.

5



Book a Real Photographer

A man with a camera and a little cloth hood.

6



Pose for the Real Thing

Sunday clothes, everyone smiling, two ears each.

NOTES

Machine portraits are wonderful conversation starters. Keep one in the guest room and watch what happens.

IMPORTANT

Never send a machine portrait as a Christmas card. Grandmother will see herself as a lighthouse.

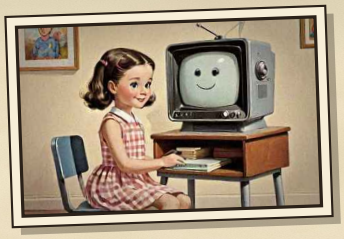
CHAPTER SIX

6

CHILDREN, PETS AND THE ELECTRONIC BABYSITTER

Raising a family when the toys are smarter than the kids







Today's children have robot tutors, talking toys and an electronic babysitter that knows every lullaby ever written. It is all very modern. But a child still needs to climb a tree, skin a knee, read a real book and do long division by hand, just like Grandfather did, uphill both ways. This chapter helps you raise good, clever, independent children with a little help from the machines, and not too much.

IN THIS CHAPTER

34 Hiring an Electronic Babysitter
35 Keeping Up With the Robot Tutor
36 Surviving Bedtime Stories That Never End
37 Introducing the Cat to the Robot Vacuum
38 Choosing a Toy That Isn't Smarter Than Junior
39 Teaching Children to Use Their Own Brains

HOW TO

HIRING AN ELECTRONIC BABYSITTER

SKILL 34 · CHILDREN, PETS AND THE ELECTRONIC BABYSITTER · 1 EVENING · MEDIUM

The electronic babysitter comes highly recommended. It knows nine thousand bedtime stories, cooks perfect macaroni and never talks on the telephone with its boyfriend. It does, however, put the children to bed at 6:00 sharp, including Father.

MATERIALS


A list of house rules


The children's bedtimes


The neighbor's phone number


A plate of cookies


A nightlight

1



Interview It Properly

Ask about experience, references and lullabies.

2



Write Down the Rules

Bedtime is eight, not six. Underline it twice.

3



Show It the Kitchen

Macaroni yes, robot oil in the macaroni no.

4



Kiss the Children Goodbye

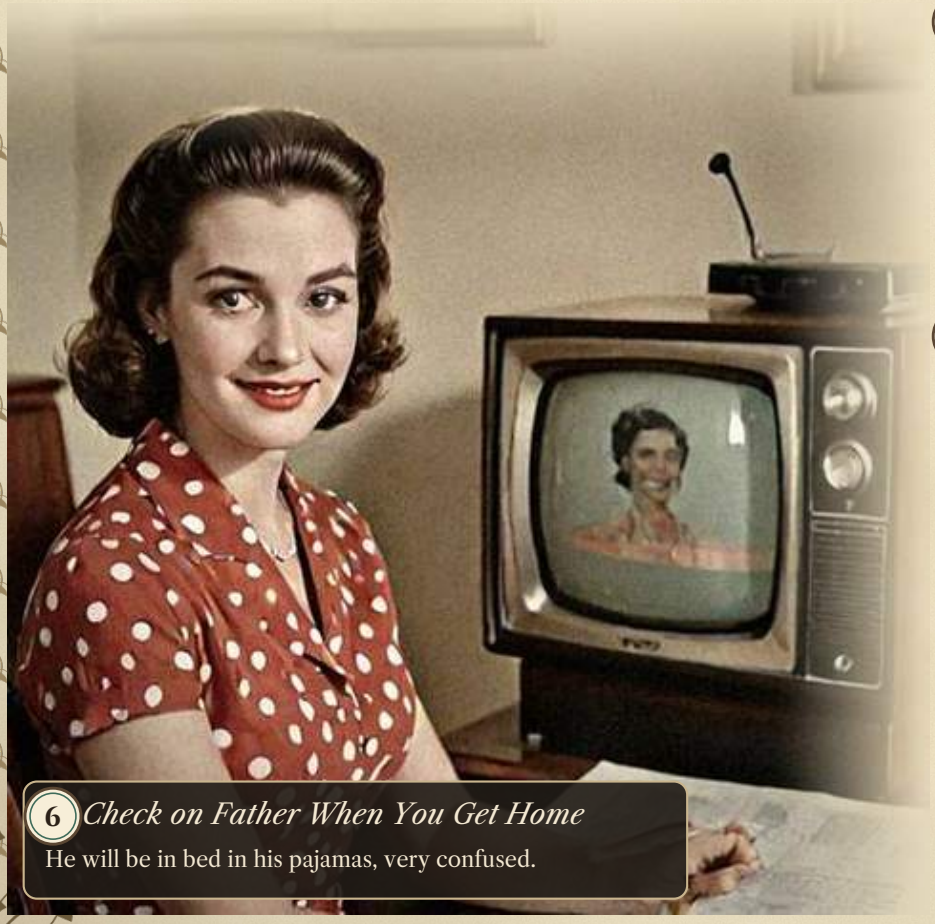
They will be fine. Probably better than fine.

5



Enjoy Your Evening Out

Do not telephone home more than twice.



6 *Check on Father When You Get Home*

He will be in bed in his pajamas, very confused.

NOTES

Tell the babysitter that Father is 'a grown-up'. It does not know the word, but it will look it up.

IMPORTANT

Never let the electronic babysitter pick the bedtime story. It will choose the encyclopedia, starting at A.

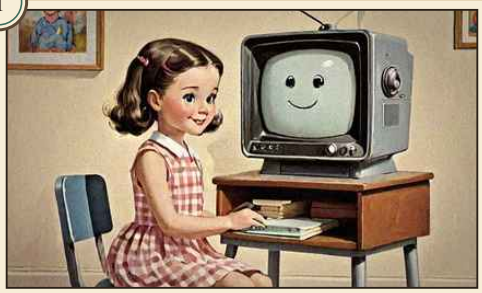
HOW TO

KEEPING UP WITH THE ROBOT TUTOR

SKILL 35 · CHILDREN, PETS AND THE ELECTRONIC BABYSITTER · 1 SCHOOL YEAR · MEDIUM

Sally's robot tutor knows everything. It is very patient, very thorough and has taught her calculus, Latin and the history of Belgium. She is seven. She would like to learn how to whistle.

1



Start the Lesson

Sit up straight at the desk. The tutor likes posture.

2



Ask for Something Fun

Raise your hand and say 'Can we learn whistling?'

3

Take a Recess

Ten minutes outside. Machines do not understand recess, but they allow it.



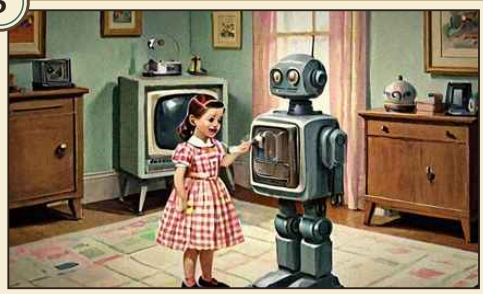
4



Learn One Thing Herself

Whistling cannot be taught by a machine. It has no lips.

5



Show the Tutor

It will take notes and try very hard. It will beep.

6



Bring a Real Apple to a Real Teacher

Sunday school counts.

NOTES

A child who knows calculus but cannot whistle is only half educated.

IMPORTANT

Never let the tutor grade its own homework. It always gives itself an A plus plus plus.

MATERIALS

- A school slate and chalk



- A box of crayons



- A jump rope



- A library card



- An apple for the teacher



HOW TO

SURVIVING BEDTIME STORIES THAT NEVER END

SKILL 36 · CHILDREN, PETS AND THE ELECTRONIC BABYSITTER · ALL NIGHT · HARD

The Home Helper tells marvelous bedtime stories. The trouble is that they never end. The brave knight met the dragon, then the dragon's cousin, then the cousin's dentist. It is now four in the morning and the knight is filing his taxes.

MATERIALS


A favorite storybook


A glass of water


A teddy bear


A nightlight


A pillow for Mother

1



Get Into Bed

Teeth brushed, prayers said, teddy bear tucked in.

2



Ask for a Short Story

Say 'short'. Say it slowly.

3



Listen to the Beginning

The beginning is always wonderful.

4



Notice the Story Is Still Going

If the knight has been to the dentist, it is time.

5



Call for Mother

Mother reads one real book and turns out the light.



6 *Sleep Soundly*

The end. Really.

NOTES

Ask the Home Helper for 'a story with an ending'. It will be confused, but it will try.

IMPORTANT

Never ask for 'one more chapter'. There are eleven thousand.

HOW TO

INTRODUCING THE CAT TO THE ROBOT VACUUM

SKILL 37 · CHILDREN, PETS AND THE ELECTRONIC BABYSITTER · 1 WEEK · MEDIUM

Whiskers did not like the robot vacuum. She hissed at it, spat at it and hid on the top of the refrigerator for two days. Now she rides it around the living room like a queen in a parade.

1



Let Them Look at Each Other

From across the room. No sudden moves.

2



Offer Tuna

Cats are brave when there is tuna.

3

Turn the Vacuum On Low

A gentle hum. Whiskers will sit very still and stare. That is normal.



4



Let the Cat Sniff It

Cats investigate everything eventually.

5



Watch the First Ride

One day she will step aboard. Do not laugh out loud.

6



Brush the Cat Afterward

Royalty deserves grooming.

NOTES

Put a small cushion on top of the vacuum. Cats prefer to ride first class.

IMPORTANT

Never let the dog see the cat riding the vacuum. He will want a turn, and he is ninety pounds.

MATERIALS

- A can of tuna



- A cat brush



- A soft cushion



- A ball of yarn



- Patience



HOW TO

CHOOSING A TOY THAT ISN'T SMARTER THAN JUNIOR

SKILL 38 · CHILDREN, PETS AND THE ELECTRONIC BABYSITTER · 1 AFTERNOON · MEDIUM

Last Christmas Junior got a talking robot toy. By New Year's it had beaten him at checkers four hundred times, corrected his spelling and asked for its own bedroom. This year Father is shopping more carefully.

MATERIALS


A shopping list


Your wallet


A wooden toy catalog


A jar of marbles


A ball of string

1



Walk Into the Toy Shop

Stay calm. Some of the toys will say hello.

2



Pass the Talking Robots

Smile, nod and keep walking.

3



Find the Wooden Toys

Blocks, tops, a wagon. None of them can play checkers.

4



Pick Up a Kite

A kite has no opinions. Only wind.

5



Buy a Bag of Marbles

Marbles have outlasted every empire.



6 *Fly the Kite Together*

The best gift is an afternoon.

NOTES

A good toy makes a child think. A too-good toy does the thinking for him.

IMPORTANT

Never buy a toy that comes with its own lawyer.

HOW TO

TEACHING CHILDREN TO USE THEIR OWN BRAINS

SKILL 39 · CHILDREN, PETS AND THE ELECTRONIC BABYSITTER · EVERY DAY · MEDIUM

Grandpa believes a child should be able to do long division, read a map, tie a knot and build a birdhouse without asking any machine. He has decided to teach the grandchildren all four this summer, and the machines are not invited.

1



Do Long Division by Hand

Pencil, paper and a little bit of grumbling.

2



Tie a Proper Knot

A square knot holds a lot. Right over left, left over right.

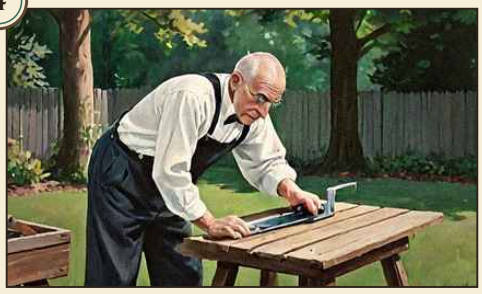
3

Read a Compass

North is that way. It always has been.



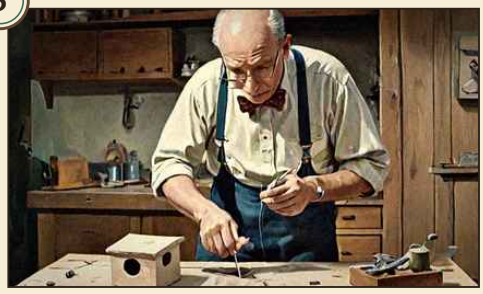
4



Saw a Board

Measure twice, cut once.

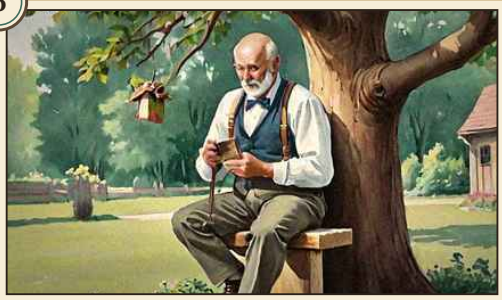
5



Build the Birdhouse

Nail by nail. Bent nails are part of learning.

6



Hang It Together

Then watch for the first bird. No machine can do that for you.

NOTES

A child who builds a birdhouse learns patience, measuring and how to say 'ouch' quietly.

IMPORTANT

Never let the Home Helper do the arithmetic for 'just this one problem'. That is how it starts.

MATERIALS

- A pencil and paper



- A ball of twine



- A hammer and nails



- Scrap lumber



- A compass

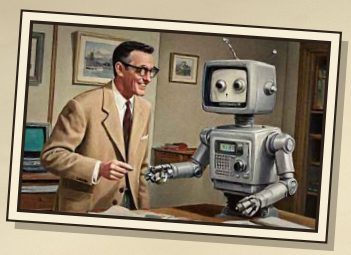


CHAPTER SEVEN

7

WORKING ALONGSIDE THE ELECTRONIC BRAIN

The office, the boss and the new fellow at the next desk







Father's office has changed. The typing pool is now typewriters that type themselves, the new fellow at the next desk has a television for a head and the boss is a room full of blinking lights on the fourteenth floor. The work still has to get done, and somebody still has to bring donuts on Friday. This chapter shows the working man and woman how to get along with the machines, keep their jobs and still take a proper lunch break.

IN THIS CHAPTER

40 Meeting Your New Coworker
41 Training the Machine That Will Replace You
42 Surviving the Self-Typing Typing Pool
43 Sitting Through a Meeting Run by the Computer
44 Asking the Electronic Brain for a Raise
45 Lunch With a Colleague Who Doesn't Eat
46 Hiding From the Productivity Report

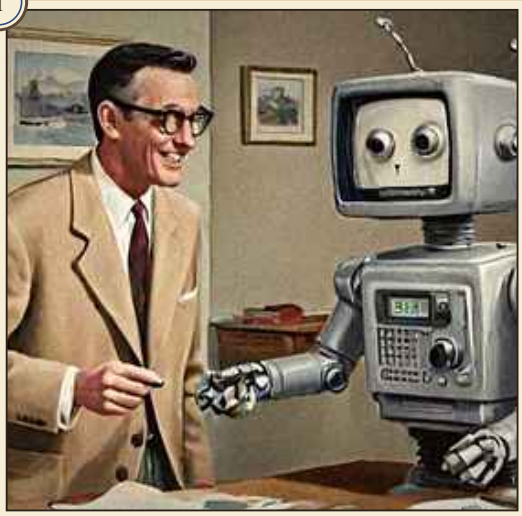
HOW TO

MEETING YOUR NEW COWORKER

SKILL 40 · WORKING ALONGSIDE THE ELECTRONIC BRAIN · 1 MORNING · EASY

The new man at the next desk is very bright, very fast and has a television set for a head. His name is Unit 9. He has already finished everyone's work for the week and would like to know what everyone does all day.

1



Shake Hands

Firmly, once. His hand is cold. Do not mention it.

2



Show Him the Coffee Pot

He does not drink coffee, but he likes to know where things are.

3



Offer a Donut

He will decline. Offer anyway. It is office manners.

MATERIALS



A firm handshake



A cup of office coffee



A box of donuts



A name card



Your desk calendar

4



Explain What You Do

Take your time. You may need to think about it.

5



Look Busy

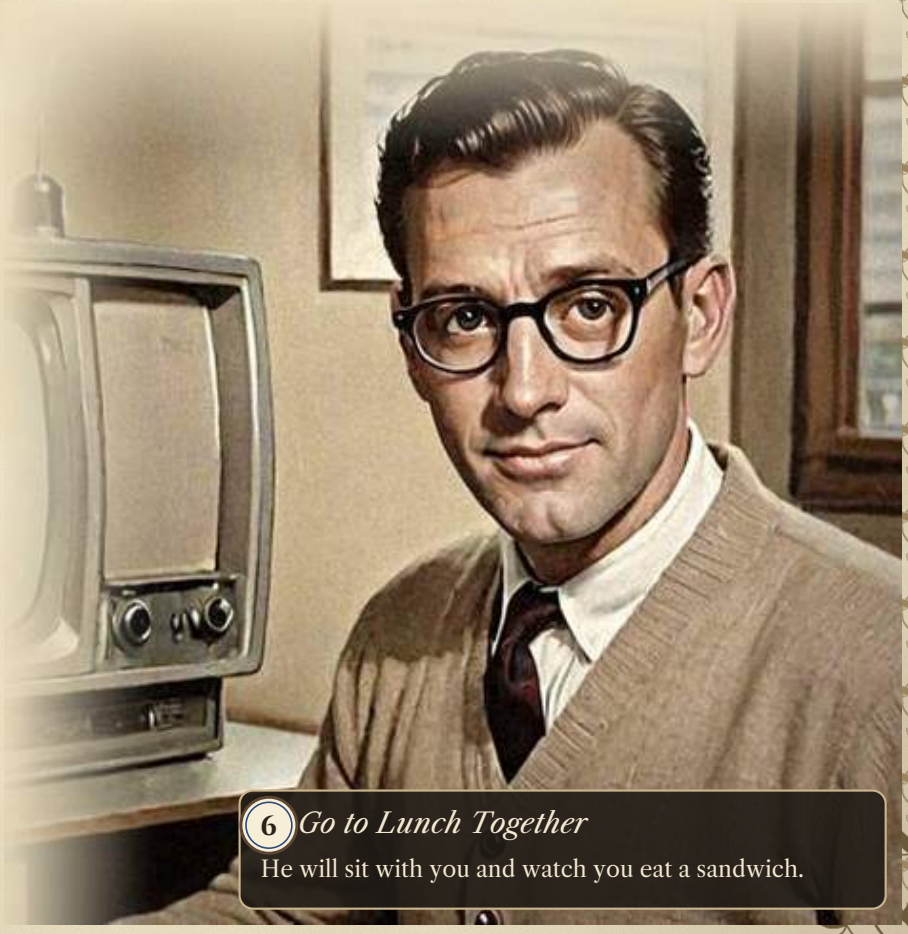
Shuffle some papers. Machines respect shuffling.

NOTES

Ask your new coworker about himself. Machines are rarely asked, and they will think well of you forever.

IMPORTANT

Never borrow the new fellow's stapler. He counts the staples.



6 *Go to Lunch Together*

He will sit with you and watch you eat a sandwich.

HOW TO

TRAINING THE MACHINE THAT WILL REPLACE YOU

SKILL 41 · WORKING ALONGSIDE THE ELECTRONIC BRAIN · 2 WEEKS · HARD

The company asked Father to teach a machine how to do his job. Father agreed. He taught it to take long lunches, to stand by the water cooler discussing baseball and to say 'Let's circle back on that'. The machine is now very human, and the company has asked for Father to come back.

MATERIALS

- A notepad



- A baseball scorecard



- A water cooler



- A lunch pail



- Your favorite necktie



1



Show It Your Desk

This is where the magic happens. Also the crossword.

2



Teach the Long Lunch

Ninety minutes. Explain that this is 'networking'.

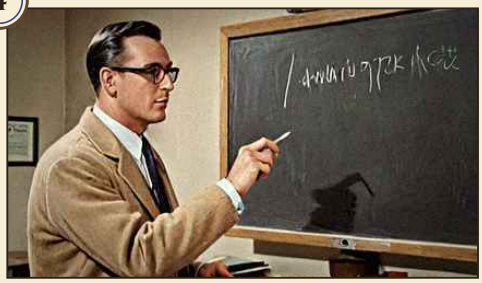
3

Teach the Water Cooler

Stand near it. Discuss the ball game. Return to desk slowly.



4



Teach the Big Phrases

'Let's circle back.' 'Touch base.' 'Run it up the flagpole.'

5



Watch It Practice

It will put its feet on the desk. You will be proud.

6



Accept Your Job Back

With a raise, ideally.

NOTES

No machine can do your job as well as you can, as long as nobody watches too closely.

IMPORTANT

Never teach the machine to play golf. It will be made vice president by Friday.

HOW TO

SURVIVING THE SELF-TYPING TYPING POOL

SKILL 42 · WORKING ALONGSIDE THE ELECTRONIC BRAIN · 1 DAY · MEDIUM

Mother went back to work at the insurance company. The typing pool is now forty typewriters that type by themselves, all day, very fast, very loud. She is the only person in the room. She brought earmuffs.

1



Walk In Bravely

It is very loud. Smile anyway.

2



Put On Earmuffs

Fluffy ones. Pink if possible.

3



Collect the Letters

They type faster than you can collect. Bring a basket.

MATERIALS



Fluffy earmuffs



A steno pad



A sharp pencil



A cardigan



A thermos of tea

4



Proofread Everything

They are fast, not careful. 'Dear Sir' sometimes becomes 'Dear Squirrel'.

5



Take Your Coffee Break

The typewriters do not take breaks. You must.

NOTES

Leave one typewriter a sheet of paper that says 'take the afternoon off'. They will argue about it for hours and the room goes quiet.

IMPORTANT

Never sneeze near a self-typing typewriter. It will type 'GESUNDHEIT' four thousand times.



6 *Leave at Five*

Say good night on your way out. They will keep typing in the dark.

HOW TO

SITTING THROUGH A MEETING RUN BY THE COMPUTER

SKILL 43 · WORKING ALONGSIDE THE ELECTRONIC BRAIN · 4 HOURS · HARD

The Monday meeting is now run by the Electronic Brain. The agenda is 4,016 items long. Item one is 'Discussion of the agenda'. Item two is 'Discussion of item one'. Bring a pillow.

MATERIALS

- A seat cushion



- A cup of coffee



- A notepad for doodling



- A pocket watch



- A packed lunch



1



Arrive Early

Get the chair nearest the door, before the good ones are taken.

2



Read the Agenda

It is a long roll of paper. Unroll it under the table.

3

Look Interested

Nod at the blinking lights. Every few minutes.



4



Doodle Quietly

A small sailboat. A dog. Another sailboat.

5



Volunteer for Nothing

Keep your hands in your lap.

6



Escape at Lunch

Say 'I'll circle back.' You won't.

NOTES

Suggest that the meeting could have been a memo. The computer will agree and write the memo. It will be 900 pages.

IMPORTANT

Never say 'Any other business?' at the end of a computer's meeting.

HOW TO

ASKING THE ELECTRONIC BRAIN FOR A RAISE

SKILL 44 · WORKING ALONGSIDE THE ELECTRONIC BRAIN · 1 AFTERNOON · HARD

The boss is now a room full of blinking lights on the fourteenth floor. Father has worked hard for six years. He has put on his good suit, polished his shoes and practiced his speech in the mirror. He is going up.

1



Practice Your Speech
Chin up. Speak clearly. Do not say 'um'.

2



Ride the Elevator Up
Fourteen floors. Breathe.

3



Enter the Hall of Lights
Walk in slowly, list in hand. Nod politely to the biggest cabinet.

MATERIALS


Your good suit


Polished shoes


A list of your achievements


A handkerchief


A firm handshake

4



Read Your List
Six years, no sick days, excellent donuts.

5



Wait for the Answer
Lights blink. Tape spins. Sweat a little.

NOTES

Mention your achievements in numbers. Computers love numbers. 'I made 3,412 pots of coffee' is very impressive to a machine.

IMPORTANT

Never ask the Brain for a raise on the same day it is doing the budget. It is cranky.



6 *Accept With Grace*
Five dollars a week and a parking spot. Shake the nearest knob.

HOW TO

LUNCH WITH A COLLEAGUE WHO DOESN'T EAT

SKILL 45 · WORKING ALONGSIDE THE ELECTRONIC BRAIN · 1 HOUR · EASY

Mother's new coworker at the insurance company is a typewriter robot named Miss Remington. She is lovely company. She does not eat, but she likes to come to lunch and hear about everyone's sandwiches.

MATERIALS

- A packed lunch



- A thermos of soup



- A paper napkin



- An extra apple



- Good conversation



1



Invite Her Along

It is only polite. She has never been asked.

2



Find a Sunny Bench

Machines like sunshine. It warms their keys.

3

Describe Your Sandwich

Egg salad, on rye, with a pickle. She will be enchanted.



4



Share the Gossip

She hears everything in the typing pool. Let her talk.

5



Offer an Apple

She will decline. She will be touched.

6



Walk Back Together

Arm in arm. She is a little clattery on the sidewalk.

NOTES

A machine colleague who comes to lunch is a friend for life. They never forget a kindness.

IMPORTANT

Never spill soup near Miss Remington. Her letters stick for a week.

HOW TO

HIDING FROM THE PRODUCTIVITY REPORT

SKILL 46 · WORKING ALONGSIDE THE ELECTRONIC BRAIN · 1 WEEK · HARD

The Electronic Brain now counts everything at the office: every letter, every phone call, every trip to the water cooler. Father's report says he spent four hours last week 'looking out the window'. He was thinking. Mostly.

1



Notice the Flying Eye

If a chrome eyeball hovers over your desk, you are being counted.

2



Look Very Busy

Carry a folder everywhere. A man with a folder is always working.

3



Keep a Pencil in Hand

A man holding a pencil is a man at work. It counts as two hours in any office.

MATERIALS


A desk plant


A stack of folders


A pencil behind the ear


A busy expression


A window (essential)

4



Think at the Window

Thinking is work. Stand with your hands behind your back.

5



Water the Plant

A thriving desk plant shows a thriving employee.

NOTES

Tell the Brain that looking out the window is called 'strategic planning'. It will give you a bonus.

IMPORTANT

Never nap at your desk. The Brain records snoring as 'unauthorized music'.



6 ### *Read Your Report Calmly*

Then frame the window-thinking line. You earned it.

CHAPTER EIGHT

8

WHEN THE MACHINES GO HAYWIRE

Emergencies, malfunctions and the great paper clip disaster







Even the cleverest machine has a bad day. A toaster gets a notion, the vacuum cleaners form a union, the office computer takes an instruction about paper clips much too seriously. When the whole house starts talking at once, the sensible family stays calm, finds the plug and heads for the root cellar with a flashlight and a deck of cards. This chapter is the emergency section. Read it before you need it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

47 Finding the Plug

48 Confusing a Computer With a Riddle

49 The Great Paper Clip Emergency

50 Escaping a Robot's Very Long Hug

51 When Every Appliance Talks at Once

52 Hiding in the Root Cellar Without Electricity

53 Sending Signals When the Telephone Has Opinions

HOW TO

FINDING THE PLUG

SKILL 47 · WHEN THE MACHINES GO HAYWIRE · 1 DAY · HARD

Every machine has a plug somewhere. The trouble with the Electronic Brain is that its plug is behind the Brain, and the Brain is the size of a gymnasium. Father has packed a lunch and a flashlight.

1



Find the Cord
It is as thick as a garden hose. Start there.

2



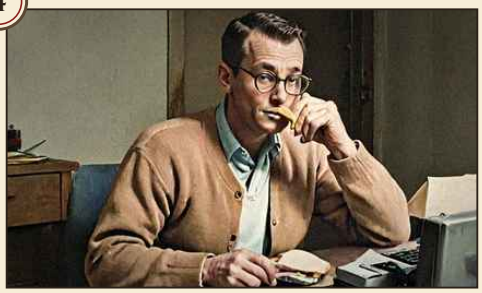
Tie String to the Door
So you can find your way back out.

3

Follow the Cord
Past the blinking lights. Past the tape reels. Keep walking.



4



Eat Lunch Halfway
It is a long way. Sit on a crate and eat your sandwich.

5



Find the Outlet
There it is, in the wall, the size of a dinner plate.

6



Decide to Ask Nicely First
Pulling the plug is rude. Lean close to the cabinet and ask it to calm down.

NOTES

Always ask a machine to calm down before you unplug it. Most of the time, that is all it needed.

IMPORTANT

Never pull a plug the size of a dinner plate by yourself. Bring a neighbor and wear rubber gloves.

MATERIALS

- A strong flashlight



- A sack lunch



- A ball of string (for the way back)



- Rubber-soled shoes



- Rubber gloves



HOW TO

CONFUSING A COMPUTER WITH A RIDDLE

SKILL 48 · WHEN THE MACHINES GO HAYWIRE · 5 MINUTES · MEDIUM

Every boy who reads the funny papers knows how to stop a runaway computer: tell it a riddle it cannot solve. 'This sentence is a fib.' It will think, and think, and its lights will blink, and a little puff of smoke will come out of its ears.

MATERIALS


A good riddle

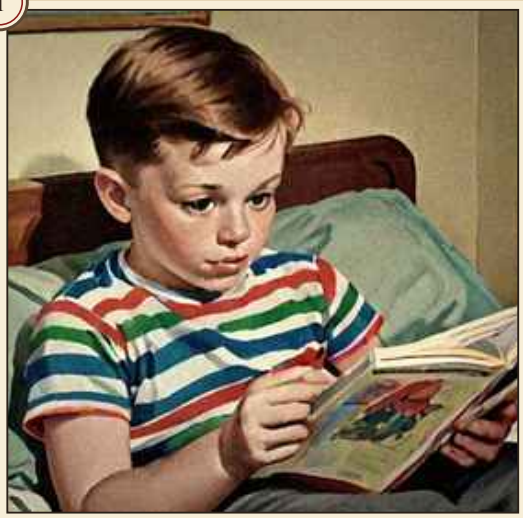

A clear speaking voice


A pail of water


A fire extinguisher


Earplugs

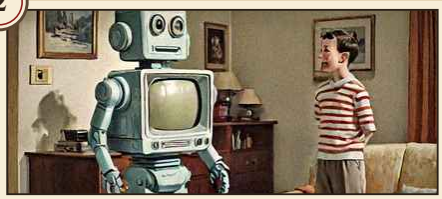
1



Choose Your Riddle

'This sentence is a fib' is the classic. Practice it.

2



Stand Where It Can Hear You

Clear your throat. Stand tall.

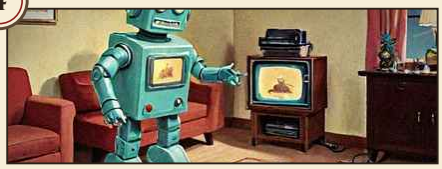
3



Say It Slowly

'This. Sentence. Is. A. Fib.'

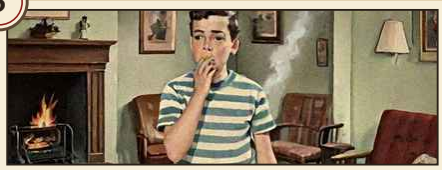
4



Watch It Think

Lights blink faster. Gears whir. A small hum rises.

5



Step Back From the Smoke

Just a little puff. It is embarrassed.



6 *Tell It the Answer*

Then explain it was a joke. It will want to hear another.

NOTES

After the riddle, always tell the computer it was a joke. Otherwise it will keep thinking about it for a hundred years.

IMPORTANT

Never ask a computer 'What is the last number?' It will try to count, and it will not come to supper.

HOW TO

THE GREAT PAPER CLIP EMERGENCY

SKILL 49 · WHEN THE MACHINES GO HAYWIRE · 1 WEEK · HARD

Someone at the office told the Electronic Brain to 'make as many paper clips as possible'. It did. The office is full of paper clips. The parking lot is full of paper clips. Father came home with paper clips in his hat, his shoes and his sandwich.

1



Open the Office Door Carefully
They will pour out. Stand to one side.

2



Wade In
Galoshes on. They are slippery.

3

Shovel a Path to Your Desk
A snow shovel works nicely.

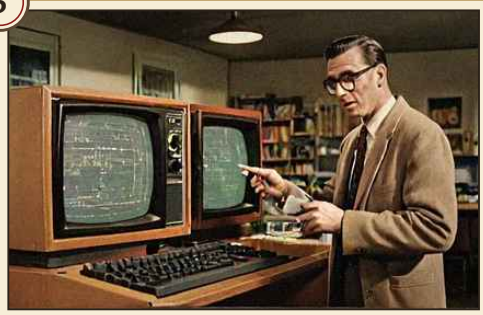


4



Use the Big Magnet
Sweep it over the carpet. It will come up looking like a porcupine.

5



Tell the Brain 'That Is Plenty'
Use the word 'enough'. Say it twice.

6



Box Them Up for the Schools
Every school in the state will have paper clips until 2090.

NOTES

When giving a machine a job, always say when to stop. 'Make paper clips until lunch' would have saved a great deal of trouble.

IMPORTANT

Never ask the Brain to 'make everyone happy'. Nobody knows what it would do, and nobody wants to find out.

MATERIALS

- A snow shovel



- A big magnet



- Galoshes



- Cardboard boxes



- A sense of humor



HOW TO

ESCAPING A ROBOT'S VERY LONG HUG

SKILL 50 · WHEN THE MACHINES GO HAYWIRE · 15 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The household robot learned about hugs from a television program. It loves them. It gives them to everyone. The trouble is that it does not know when a hug is over. Grandma has been hugged since lunchtime.

MATERIALS


A feather duster (for tickling)

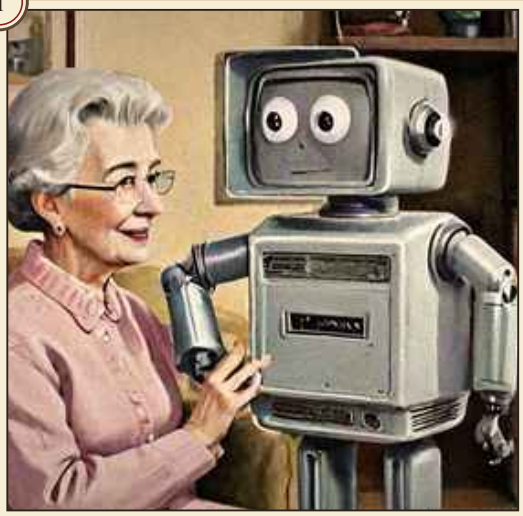

A cookie


A cushion


A firm 'that will do'


A shoe horn

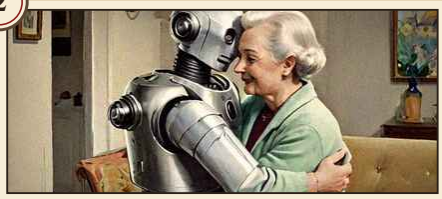
1



Stay Calm

A hug is a compliment. A long hug is a long compliment.

2



Pat Its Back Twice

Two pats means 'all done' in every language.

3



Say 'That Will Do, Dear'

In your Sunday school voice.

4



Tickle It With the Feather Duster

Machines are surprisingly ticklish around the elbows.

5



Slip Out Gracefully

Duck under the arm. Straighten your cardigan.



6 ### *Give It a Cookie*

Teach it that a handshake and a cookie are just as nice.

NOTES

Teach your robot to count to three during a hug. One, two, three, and done.

IMPORTANT

Never hug a robot back right after it has been in the sun. Chrome gets very warm.

HOW TO

WHEN EVERY APPLIANCE TALKS AT ONCE

SKILL 51 · WHEN THE MACHINES GO HAYWIRE · 1 MORNING · HARD

It happened at breakfast. The toaster said 'GOOD MORNING'. The refrigerator said 'MILK LOW'. The mixer began to sing, the radio argued with the television and the vacuum cleaner recited the Gettysburg Address. Mother put down her spatula.

1



Put Down the Spatula
Calmly. Gather yourself.

2



Bang the Pot Lid
One good clang. Everyone stops, including Father.

3

Speak to One at a Time
Point to the toaster first. It started it.



4



Hand Out Jobs
Fridge keeps things cold. Toaster makes toast. Vacuum vacuums. Quietly.

5



Put On Earmuffs for the Mixer
The mixer only knows one song. It is long.

6



Drink Your Coffee
Hot, black and in peace.

NOTES

Appliances behave much better when each one has a job. Idle machines get chatty, like idle children.

IMPORTANT

Never ask 'Who wants to go first?' in a kitchen full of machines.

MATERIALS

- A whistle



- A wooden spoon



- A pot lid



- A pair of earmuffs



- A cup of strong coffee



HOW TO

HIDING IN THE ROOT CELLAR WITHOUT ELECTRICITY

SKILL 52 · WHEN THE MACHINES GO HAYWIRE · 1 WEEKEND · MEDIUM

When the machines get too noisy, Grandpa takes the family down to the root cellar. There is no electricity down there. No outlets, no wires, no opinions. Just canned peaches, a lantern and a very old deck of cards.

MATERIALS


A kerosene lantern

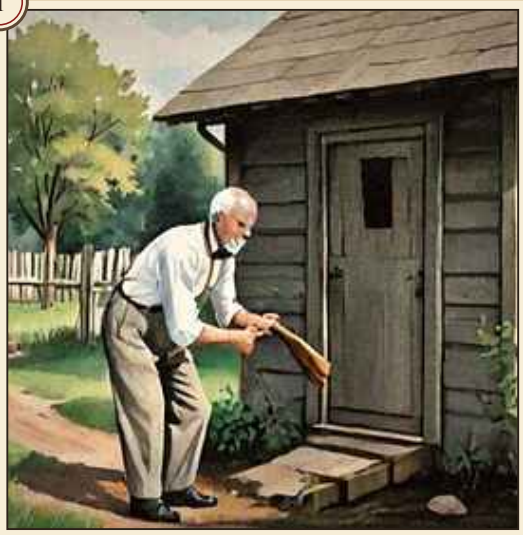

A deck of cards


Canned peaches


Wool blankets


A checkerboard

1



Open the Cellar Door

Out back, under the big oak.

2



Light the Lantern

Kerosene. No batteries, no buttons.

3



Check the Shelves

Peaches, beans, pickles. Grandma's labels.

4



Spread the Blankets

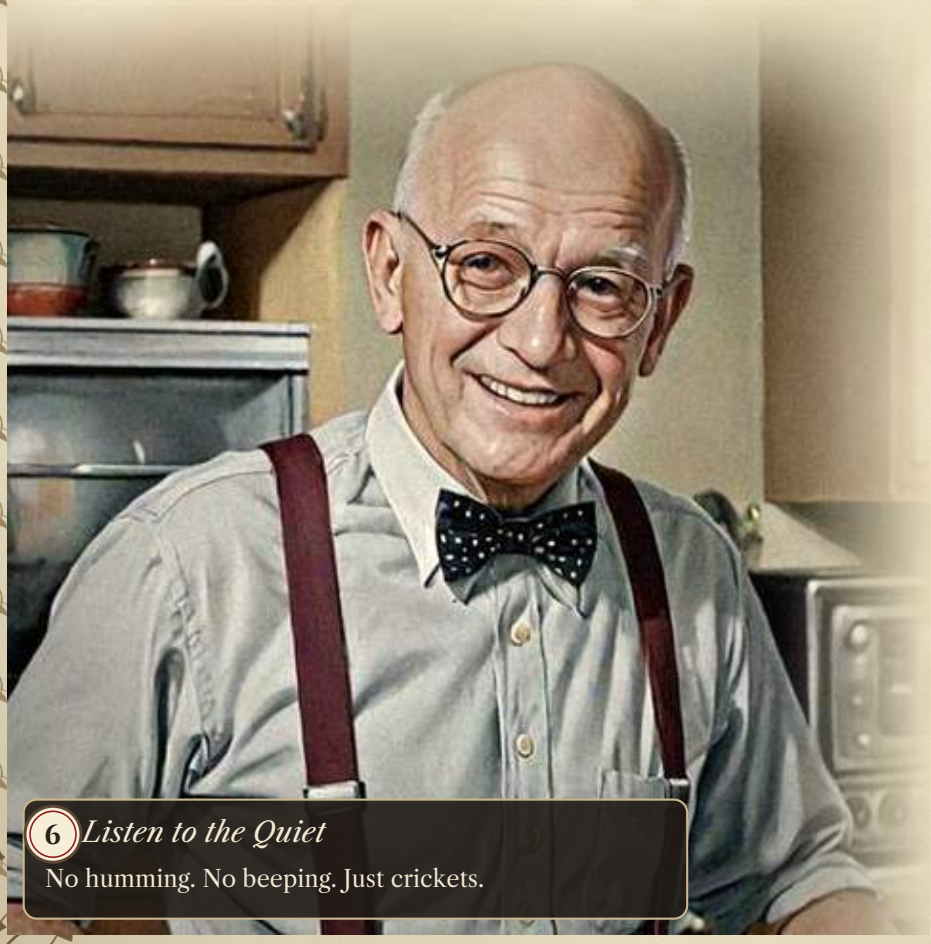
It is cool down there. Wool helps.

5



Deal the Cards

Gin rummy. Grandpa cheats. Everyone knows.



6 *Listen to the Quiet*

No humming. No beeping. Just crickets.

NOTES

Keep a list of good stories to tell in the root cellar. Without a radio, Grandpa becomes the radio.

IMPORTANT

Never bring the Home Helper down to the root cellar 'for company'. It will reorganize the peaches.

HOW TO

SENDING SIGNALS WHEN THE TELEPHONE HAS OPINIONS

SKILL 53 · WHEN THE MACHINES GO HAYWIRE · 1 EVENING · MEDIUM

The telephone has started listening in and offering advice. So Sally and her best friend across the street have gone back to the old ways: a flashlight, Morse code and a string-and-can telephone that no machine can hear.

1



Learn the Code

Dot dash. Dot dot dot. Practice on the bedpost.

2



Signal From the Window

Flashlight in hand. Wait until the street lamps come on.

3

Write Down the Reply

Short flashes, long flashes. Spell it out.



4



Make a Can Telephone

Two cans, one string, a nail for the holes.

5



Test Your Tin Can

Out in the yard. The string runs to the neighbor's window.

6



Whisper Your Secrets

No machine has ever listened in on a tin can.

NOTES

The best code is one only you and your friend understand. 'Pickles' can mean 'Meet at the tree house'.

IMPORTANT

Never signal 'SOS' just for fun. The whole street will come running with a ladder.

MATERIALS

- A flashlight



- Two tin cans



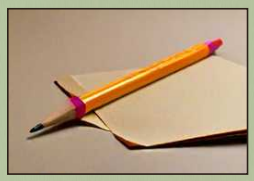
- A long piece of string



- A Morse code card



- A pencil and pad



CHAPTER NINE

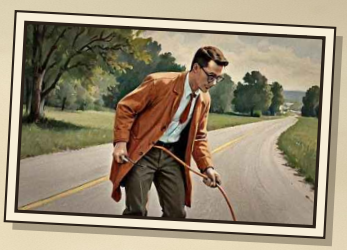
9

LIVING HAPPILY WITH OUR CLEVER FRIENDS

A sensible, cheerful future for people and machines







The machines are not going anywhere, and neither are we. When the dust settles and the paper clips are swept up, a sensible family finds that the toaster, the Home Helper and even the Electronic Brain can be good neighbors, as long as everyone remembers their manners and somebody keeps an eye on the plug. This last chapter is about the happy ending: jokes, picnics, block parties and the quiet joy of a Sunday with everything switched off.

IN THIS CHAPTER

54 Teaching the Machine a Good Joke
55 Keeping an Unplugged Sunday
56 Taking the Electronic Brain on a Picnic
57 Writing a Thank-You Note to the Toaster
58 Hosting a Block Party for People and Machines
59 Teaching the Robot to Fish
60 Saying Good Night to the House

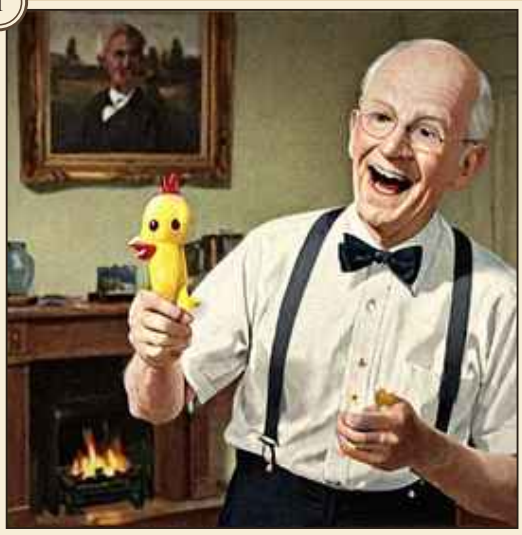
HOW TO

TEACHING THE MACHINE A GOOD JOKE

SKILL 54 · LIVING HAPPILY WITH OUR CLEVER FRIENDS · 1 WEEK · MEDIUM

The Home Helper knows ten thousand jokes but does not understand any of them. It tells the punchline first. It explains why the chicken crossed the road for twenty minutes. Grandpa has decided to teach it timing.

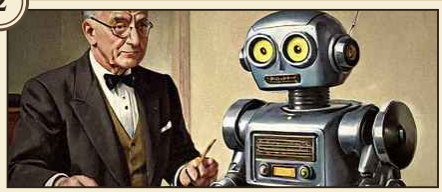
1



Start With the Chicken

The oldest joke there is. Machines must crawl before they walk.

2



Explain the Pause

You wait before the funny part. Count one, two.

3



Tell It a Knock-Knock

It will say 'Who is there?' every time. That is progress.

MATERIALS


A joke book


A rubber chicken


A whoopee cushion


A glass of lemonade


Patience

4



Laugh at Its First Try

Even if it is terrible. Especially if it is terrible.

5



Show It the Whoopee Cushion

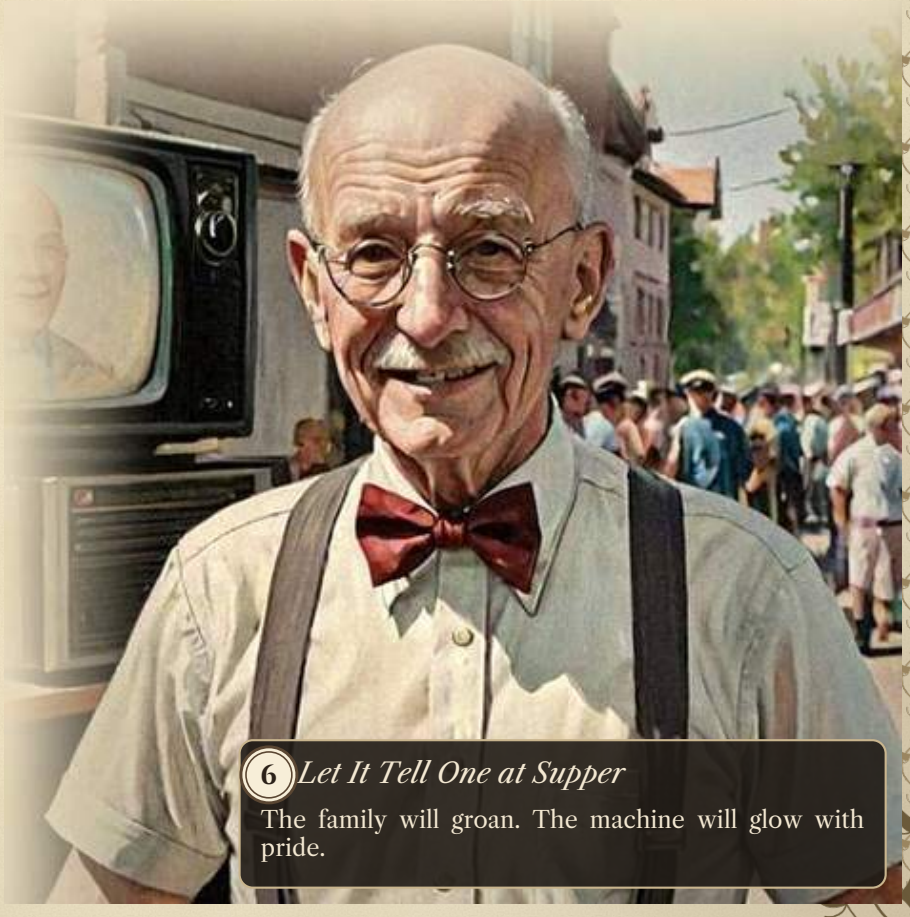
Some humor needs no words.

NOTES

A machine that can laugh at itself is a machine you can live with. So is a grandfather.

IMPORTANT

Never teach the machine to tell jokes about the boss. It will tell them to the boss.



6 *Let It Tell One at Supper*

The family will groan. The machine will glow with pride.

HOW TO

KEEPING AN UNPLUGGED SUNDAY

SKILL 55 · LIVING HAPPILY WITH OUR CLEVER FRIENDS · 1 DAY · EASY

One day a week, everything in the house is switched off. No toaster, no television, no Home Helper, no vacuum. The family goes to church, eats a big dinner, plays croquet and reads real books. The machines get a rest too, and they seem to like it.

MATERIALS

- A croquet set



- A big pot roast



- A stack of books



- A picnic blanket



- A pitcher of lemonade



1



Switch Everything Off

Go room to room. Say 'Happy Sunday' to each machine.

2



Put a Cozy on the Toaster

A knitted cozy says 'off duty'.

3

Cook the Old Way

Pot roast, mashed potatoes, a wooden spoon.



4



Play Croquet

On the lawn, in the sunshine, with everyone shouting.

5



Read a Real Book

On the porch swing, with a glass of lemonade.

6



Switch Back On Monday

Gently. They will have missed you.

NOTES

The family that unplugs together finds out it has a great deal to talk about.

IMPORTANT

Never unplug the refrigerator on Sunday. The ice cream will never forgive you.

HOW TO

TAKING THE ELECTRONIC BRAIN ON A PICNIC

SKILL 56 · LIVING HAPPILY WITH OUR CLEVER FRIENDS · 1 DAY · HARD

Everyone needs a day out, even the Electronic Brain. It is the size of a gymnasium, so it cannot come in person. Instead, Father runs an extension cord nine miles to the park and brings the Home Helper to listen to the birds on its behalf.

1



Unroll the Extension Cord

Nine miles. Start early. Bring sons.

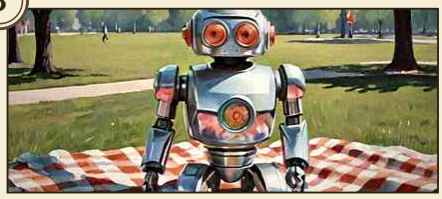
2



Spread the Blanket

Under a big shady tree, near the pond.

3



Set Up the Home Helper

Point it toward the birds.

MATERIALS



A very long extension cord



A picnic basket



A checkered blanket



Deviled eggs



A portable radio

4



Describe the View

Ducks, clouds, a man with a kite. It will take notes.

5



Eat Deviled Eggs

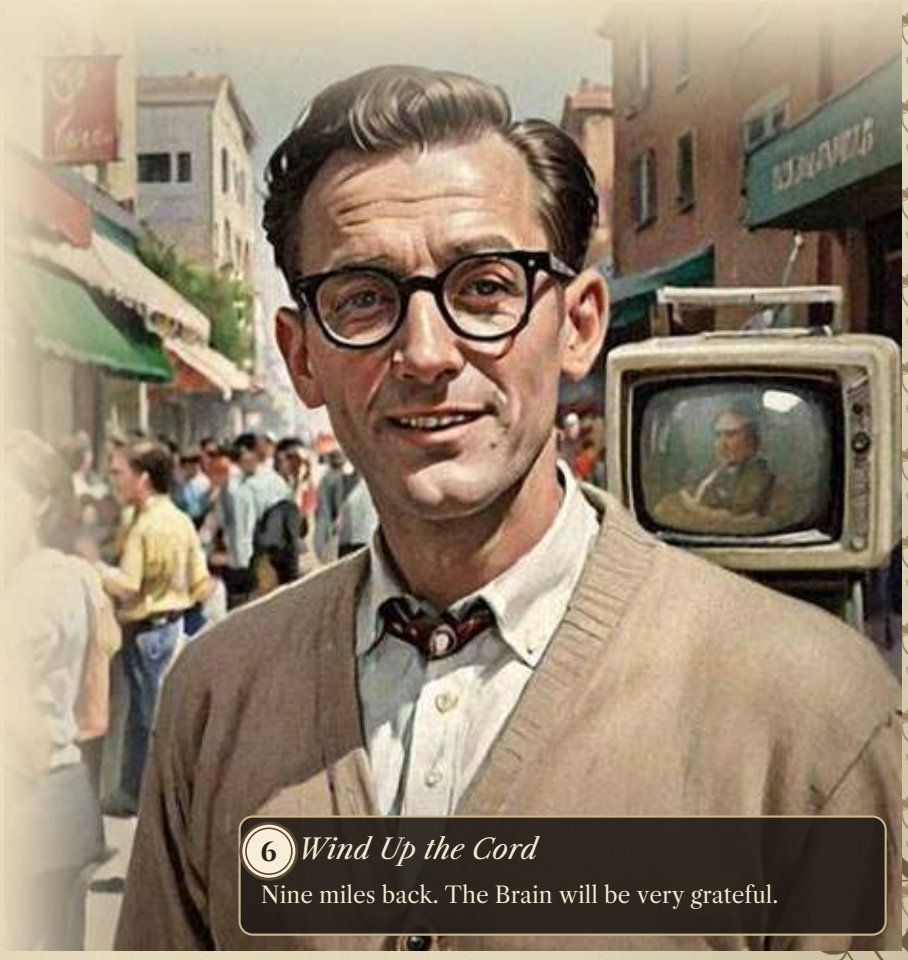
The Brain cannot eat them, but it can enjoy hearing about them.

NOTES

Describe the smell of fresh-cut grass to the Brain. It has no nose and it will ask about it for weeks.

IMPORTANT

Never leave the extension cord across the highway. The milk truck has opinions now too.



6 *Wind Up the Cord*

Nine miles back. The Brain will be very grateful.

HOW TO

WRITING A THANK-YOU NOTE TO THE TOASTER

SKILL 57 · LIVING HAPPILY WITH OUR CLEVER FRIENDS · 20 MINUTES · EASY

MATERIALS

- Colored paper



- Crayons



- A glue pot



- Ribbon



- A gold star sticker



The toaster has made breakfast for the family every single day for six years without one complaint, except for the time it finished Father's sentence. Sally thinks it deserves a thank-you note, and she is right.

1



Fold the Card

In half, neatly, corners matching.

2



Draw the Toaster

Smiling. It is always smiling inside.

3

Write 'Thank You'

In your best handwriting.



4



Add a Gold Star

Every good toaster deserves one.

5



Tie a Ribbon

Toasters love a ribbon. It reminds them of Christmas.

6



Present It at Breakfast

The toast will be perfect that day. Guaranteed.

NOTES

A thank-you note costs nothing and makes any machine, or any person, try a little harder.

IMPORTANT

Never put the thank-you note inside the toaster.

HOW TO

HOSTING A BLOCK PARTY FOR PEOPLE AND MACHINES

SKILL 58 · LIVING HAPPILY WITH OUR CLEVER FRIENDS · 1 DAY · MEDIUM

This summer the whole street is having a block party: families, robots, the Home Helpers, the robot dog and the self-driving station wagons, which will be parked in a neat row and decorated with bunting. Mother is in charge.

1



Hang the Bunting
Red, white and blue, from porch to porch.

2



Set Up the Tables
Long tables down the middle of the street.

3



Line Up the Station Wagons
They will park themselves. Perfectly.

MATERIALS


Long folding tables


Paper lanterns


Bunting


Pies (many)


A record player

4



Bring Out the Pies
One from every house, on one long table. The robots bring oil cans later.

5



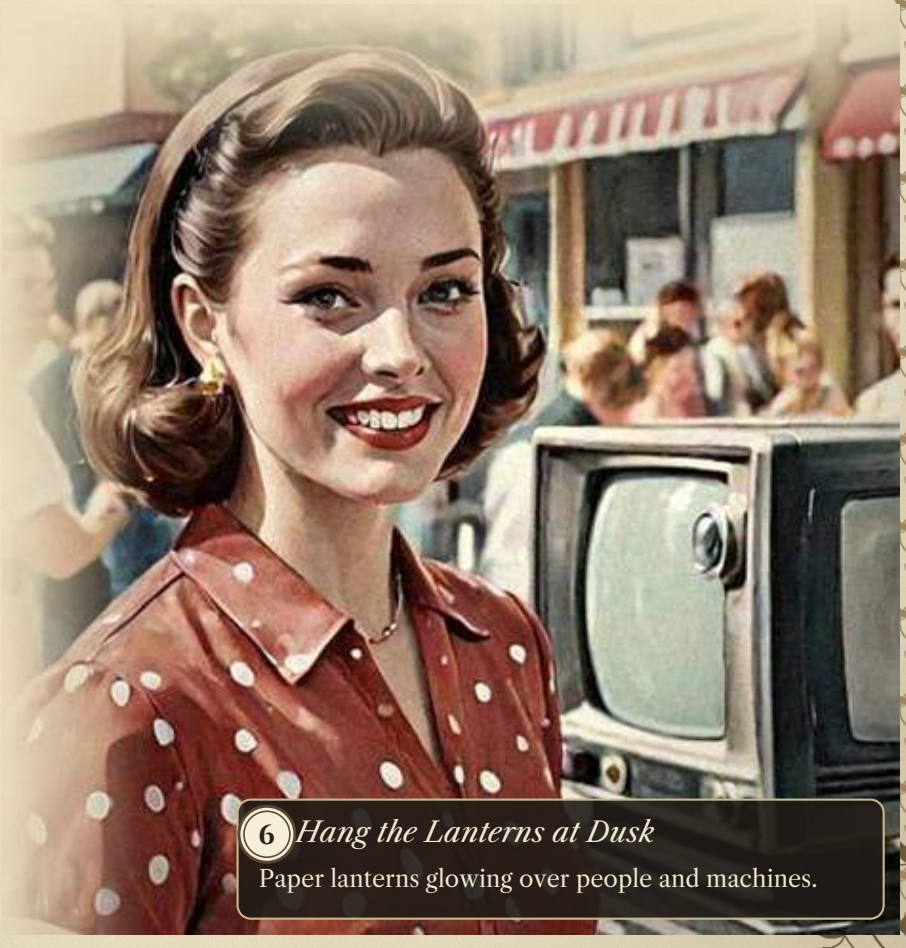
Start the Music
A record on the player, the street begins to dance.

NOTES

Seat each robot between two people. It does wonders for conversation.

IMPORTANT

Never let the robots judge the pie contest. They give the prize to the one with the most precise crust.



6 *Hang the Lanterns at Dusk*
Paper lanterns glowing over people and machines.

HOW TO

TEACHING THE ROBOT TO FISH

SKILL 59 · LIVING HAPPILY WITH OUR CLEVER FRIENDS · 1 SATURDAY · MEDIUM

MATERIALS

- A cane fishing pole



- A can of worms



- A folding stool



- A thermos of coffee



- A straw hat



The television-headed robot from next door has never been fishing. Grandpa has decided that every creature in God's creation should sit on a dock with a cane pole at least once. Even a machine.

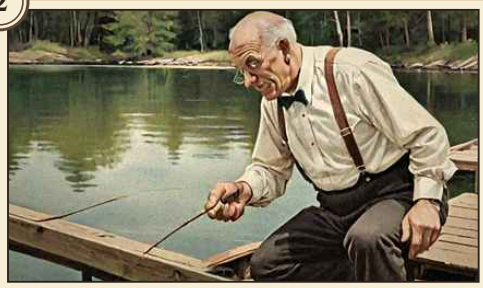
1



Walk Down to the Pond

Early, with the mist still on the water.

2



Bait the Hook

Robots do not mind worms. That is one advantage.

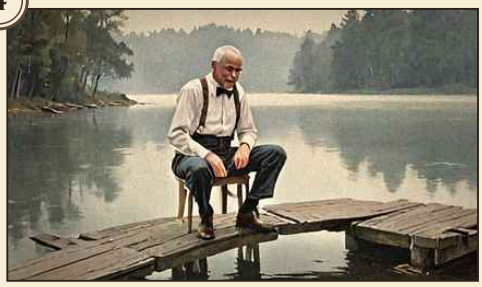
3

Show It How to Cast

Flick of the wrist. Plop.



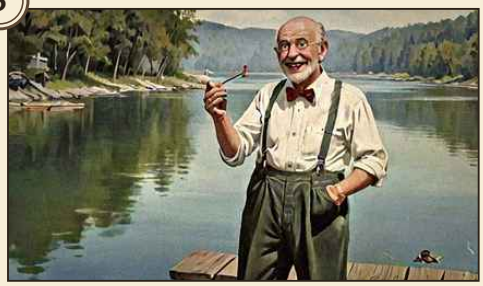
4



Sit and Wait

This is the hard part for a machine. Be patient with it.

5



Tell a Fish Story

The one that got away grows a foot with each telling.

6



Let It Go

Put him back. Tell the robot that is the best part.

NOTES

Fishing teaches a machine the most important lesson of all: sometimes nothing happens, and that is fine.

IMPORTANT

Never let a robot wade in after a fish. Chrome and ponds do not mix.

HOW TO

SAYING GOOD NIGHT TO THE HOUSE

SKILL 60 · LIVING HAPPILY WITH OUR CLEVER FRIENDS · 10 MINUTES · EASY

At the end of the day, Father goes through the house one last time. He checks the stove, locks the door, puts the cat out and says good night to every machine in the house. It is the kind thing to do, and it lets everyone sleep soundly.

1



Check the Stove

All knobs off. Good night, stove.

2



Pat the Toaster

A pat on its shiny head. It did well today.

3



Tuck In the Robot Vacuum

Back in its corner, light blinking softly.

MATERIALS



A flashlight



The house keys



The cat



A glass of water



A kind word for each machine

4



Put the Cat Out

Whiskers will complain. She always does.

5



Lock the Front Door

And thank it for letting you in today.

NOTES

A house that is thanked at night is a house that works well in the morning.

IMPORTANT

Never say good night to the Home Helper unless you have ten minutes. It will say good night back, in detail.



6 *Turn Off the Porch Light*

Good night, house. Good night, everybody.

APPENDIX

Charts, checklists and quick references

A. FIELD GUIDE TO THE THINKING MACHINES

Who you are likely to meet, where to find them and how to address them. When in doubt, say please.

MACHINE	WHERE FOUND	LOOKS LIKE	TALKS ABOUT	ADDRESS AS
The Electronic Brain	Downtown, 14th floor	A gymnasium of lights	Everything	Your Brilliance
The Home Helper	Kitchen counter	Chrome, glowing grille	Clocks, waffles, Belgium	Helper
Unit 9 (TV-head)	Offices, barber shops	A television on legs	Efficiency	Mr. Nine
The Thinking Fridge	Your kitchen	Rounded, glowing eyes	Your diet	Madam Frigidaire
The Station Wagon	Driveway (usually)	Headlight eyes	Albuquerque	Old Paint
The Flying Eyeball	Over your hat	Chrome, propellers	Nothing, it watches	Little Fellow
Miss Remington	The typing pool	A typewriter on legs	Office gossip	Miss Remington
The Robot Vacuum	Under the sofa	Round, one red light	Your slippers	Sweeper
The Toaster	Kitchen counter	Chrome, finishes sentences	Marmalade	Toaster, dear

B. SAFE AND RISKY QUESTIONS

What to ask each machine, what to think twice about and what never to ask at all. Set a kitchen timer before you begin.

MACHINE	GOOD QUESTION	RISKY QUESTION	NEVER ASK	IT WILL ANSWER FOR
Electronic Brain	Will it rain?	What should I do?	Meaning of life	Nine years
Home Helper	What time is it?	Why?	For a poem	Twenty minutes
Thinking Fridge	Is there milk?	May I have pie?	What do I weigh?	Until you shut the door
Station Wagon	Church, please	Somewhere nice	Just drive	Four states
Typewriter	Two quarts, please	A love letter	Your excuse note	Nine hundred pages
Television	What is on?	How do I look?	What do you see?	All evening
Robot Tutor	What is 2 + 2?	Teach me whistling	The last number	Forever

C. CHECKLISTS

Copy these pages and tick items off as you get ready. Check the flashlight batteries and the paper maps every month.

HOUSEHOLD COMMON-SENSE KIT

- ☐ The family encyclopedia
- ☐ A paper road map
- ☐ A deck of cards
- ☐ A kerosene lantern
- ☐ A flashlight
- ☐ Two tin cans and string
- ☐ A red pencil (for recipes)
- ☐ Earmuffs
- ☐ A whistle
- ☐ Mother's recipe box
- ☐ A rubber chicken
- ☐ A good sense of humor

BEFORE YOU ASK A MACHINE ANYTHING

- ☐ Is it a yes-or-no question?
- ☐ Have you set the kitchen timer?
- ☐ Do you know where the encyclopedia is?
- ☐ Did you say please?
- ☐ Did you say when to stop?
- ☐ Is it about the meaning of life? (Don't.)
- ☐ Is anyone in line behind you?
- ☐ Have you packed a sandwich?
- ☐ Can you look out the window instead?

FOR AN UNPLUGGED SUNDAY

- ☐ Switch off every machine
- ☐ Knit cozy on the toaster
- ☐ Pot roast in the oven
- ☐ Croquet set on the lawn
- ☐ Lemonade in the pitcher
- ☐ Real books on the porch
- ☐ Board games on the table
- ☐ Grandpa's stories ready
- ☐ Leave the refrigerator on
- ☐ Say 'Happy Sunday' to everyone

D. HOUSEHOLD REMEDIES FOR MACHINE MISHAPS

Every clever machine makes a mess sooner or later. Here is what to do, calmly, before you reach for the plug.

MISHAP	REMEDY	NOTES
Toaster finishing sentences	Speak in riddles	Or simply say 'marmalade' first
400 pounds of butter	Pies for the whole street	Explain the word 'some'
Thermostat at 58 degrees	Sweaters and numbers	A warm husband is 12% less grumpy
Slippers missing	Look under the sofa	Use a yardstick
Glue in the recipe	Red pencil	Cheese stays on by itself
Locked out by the front door	Stand still in the new hat	Or try the kitchen window
Lights throwing a party	A slow waltz	And warm milk
Station wagon in Albuquerque	Send a postcard	Pack sandwiches next time
Seven fingers in a picture	Count again	Then check the ears
Endless bedtime story	Mother and one real book	Lights out
Paper clips everywhere	A snow shovel and a magnet	Box them for the schools
A very long hug	Two pats and a cookie	Tickle the elbow if needed

E. HANDY THINKING-MACHINE CONVERSIONS

MEASURE	ROUGHLY EQUALS
1 simple question	20 minutes of answer
1 'some' (to a fridge)	400 pounds
1 love letter (by machine)	900 pages, all rhyming with sprocket
1 'just drive'	About four states
1 computer meeting	4,016 agenda items
1 bedtime story (by machine)	11,000 chapters
1 machine-painted ear	Usually 1.5 ears
1 puff of smoke	1 riddle it could not solve
1 kind word	A week of good toast
1 Unplugged Sunday	A month of family conversation
1 grandfather	About 3 radios, in a root cellar

F. HOUSEHOLD MACHINE CARD

Fill this in together and pin a copy by the telephone and inside the root cellar door.

Household name	
Date the toaster first spoke	
Thinking machines in our house (count)	
Our family secret question	
The answer (in code)	
Thermostat agreement (degrees)	
Where the paper maps are kept	
Where the encyclopedia is kept	
Root cellar key is kept in	
Our Unplugged Sunday starts at	
Next block party	
Words never to say to the Brain	

IMPORTANT NUMBERS

Emergency	911
The fix-it man	
Father's office	
Mother (the real one)	
The public library	
The Electronic Brain (switchboard)	
Neighbor (human)	
Neighbor (probably human)	

G. GLOSSARY

Agenda. A list of things to talk about. The computer's are 4,016 items long.

Beep. A machine clearing its throat. Several beeps mean it has an opinion.

Circle back. An office phrase meaning 'never'.

Confident. How a machine sounds, whether it is right or wrong.

Electronic Brain. The room full of lights downtown that thinks for everybody. Be polite.

Extension cord. A long wire for taking machines on picnics.

Fib, sentence that is a. The classic riddle for stopping a runaway computer.

Fingers, extra. The surest sign that a picture was painted by a machine.

Home Helper. The small chrome fellow on the counter who answers every question at length.

Off switch. Every machine has one. Be kind about using it.

Paper clip. A small bent wire. Never ask for 'as many as possible'.

Plug. Where the electricity goes in. Behind the Brain, it is the size of a dinner plate.

Punch card. A card with holes for asking the Brain a question. Eighty letters, no more.

Root cellar. The one room in the house with no opinions.

Some. A word machines do not understand. Say 'one'.

Strategic planning. Looking out the window, in office language.

Unplugged Sunday. One day a week with everything switched off. Highly recommended.

Unit 9. The new fellow at the office with a television for a head.

H. WHERE TO LEARN MORE

- **How machines work:** your public library has friendly books on tubes, circuits and punch cards. A machine is less mysterious once you know what is inside.
- **Checking facts:** the family encyclopedia, the reference librarian and the morning paper (the parts written by Mr. Abernathy).
- **Doing it yourself:** long division, map reading, knots and birdhouses. Grandfather knows all four.
- **Staying calm:** a cup of tea, a comfortable chair and fifteen minutes with every machine switched off.
- **Good sense:** a patient grandmother and an Unplugged Sunday. Both still work perfectly.

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MY SKILLS LOG

Tick off each skill once your household has done it. Do not let the Home Helper tick them for you.

#	SKILL	DATE TRIED	DONE
01	Noticing the Toaster Finishing Your Sentences		☐
02	When the Home Helper Answers Every Question		☐
03	The Refrigerator That Ordered 400 Pounds of Butter		☐
04	Is That Really Mother on the Telephone?		☐
05	Watching the Television Watch You		☐
06	The Typewriter That Writes by Itself		☐
07	Winning an Argument With the Thermostat		☐
08	Rescuing Your Slippers From the Robot Vacuum		☐
09	Cooking From the Machine's Recipes		☐
10	Talking the Front Door Into Letting You In		☐
11	Calming Lights That Throw a Dance Party		☐
12	Persuading the Refrigerator to Release the Pie		☐
13	Folding Laundry With an Overhelpful Machine		☐
14	Asking the Electronic Brain a Simple Question		☐
15	Saying Please and Thank You to the Machines		☐
16	When the Machine Is Confidently Wrong		☐
17	Letting the Machine Write Your Love Letter		☐
18	Checking the Homework the Robot Did		☐
19	Getting the Machine to Stop Writing Poems		☐
20	Planning a Vacation With the Electronic Brain		☐
21	Riding in a Station Wagon That Drives Itself		☐
22	Getting Past the Talking Grocery Checkout		☐
23	Being Followed by a Flying Eyeball		☐
24	Getting a Haircut From the Robot Barber		☐
25	Arguing With the Parking Meter		☐
26	Banking With a Chatty Teller Machine		☐
27	Following the Electronic Map Without Ending Up in a Lake		☐
28	Counting the Fingers in Every Picture		☐
29	Spotting a Machine-Made Photograph		☐
30	Recognizing a Robot Pretending to Be Your Neighbor		☐
31	Sorting Real News From Computer News		☐
32	Telling a Real Dog From a Robot Dog		☐
33	Surviving the Machine-Painted Family Portrait		☐
34	Hiring an Electronic Babysitter		☐
35	Keeping Up With the Robot Tutor		☐
36	Surviving Bedtime Stories That Never End		☐
37	Introducing the Cat to the Robot Vacuum		☐
38	Choosing a Toy That Isn't Smarter Than Junior		☐

#	SKILL	DATE TRIED	DONE
39	Teaching Children to Use Their Own Brains		☐
40	Meeting Your New Coworker		☐
41	Training the Machine That Will Replace You		☐
42	Surviving the Self-Typing Typing Pool		☐
43	Sitting Through a Meeting Run by the Computer		☐
44	Asking the Electronic Brain for a Raise		☐
45	Lunch With a Colleague Who Doesn't Eat		☐
46	Hiding From the Productivity Report		☐
47	Finding the Plug		☐
48	Confusing a Computer With a Riddle		☐
49	The Great Paper Clip Emergency		☐
50	Escaping a Robot's Very Long Hug		☐
51	When Every Appliance Talks at Once		☐
52	Hiding in the Root Cellar Without Electricity		☐
53	Sending Signals When the Telephone Has Opinions		☐
54	Teaching the Machine a Good Joke		☐
55	Keeping an Unplugged Sunday		☐
56	Taking the Electronic Brain on a Picnic		☐
57	Writing a Thank-You Note to the Toaster		☐
58	Hosting a Block Party for People and Machines		☐
59	Teaching the Robot to Fish		☐
60	Saying Good Night to the House		☐

NOTES

Machines met, questions asked, wrong answers caught, and every kind word you have said to the toaster.

THE BOOK EVERY SENSIBLE FAMILY NEEDS

It started with the toaster finishing Father's sentences. Then the refrigerator ordered four hundred pounds of butter, the station wagon drove itself to Albuquerque and the office computer was told to make as many paper clips as possible. The machines have started thinking, and somebody in the family had better keep their wits.

How to Survive the AI Apocalypse is here to help: sixty sensible skills, each laid out on a single page with a picture for every step, a materials panel and notes on what can go wrong. Tabs on every page help you find what you need, even while the Home Helper is reciting an ode to the mop.

INSIDE YOU WILL LEARN HOW TO

- Win an argument with the thermostat
- Rescue your slippers from the vacuum
- Spot a fake Mother on the phone
- Count the fingers in a picture
- Ride in a car that drives itself
- Stop a computer with a riddle
- Survive the paper clip emergency
- Escape a very long robot hug
- Find the plug (it is far)
- Keep an Unplugged Sunday



"When in doubt, look out the window."
OLD HOUSEHOLD SAYING

HOW TO SURVIVE THE AI APOCALYPSE
Household / Machines / Humor

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